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Eivind Knapskog

Academic supervisor:

Eduard Zulfatovich Galimullin

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Introduction

The transatlantic relationship has been a mainstay in modern international life, tying North America and Europe together economically, politically and militarily since the late 1940s. Transatlantic relations were initially conceived as a response to contextual, historical factors, most notably the looming financial crisis following the destruction of the Second World War and the need for reconstruction of European economies, as well as the increasingly hostile and competitive interaction between the United States and the Soviet Union. The creation of NATO in 1949 was then a milestone both in rapprochement between the two sides of the Atlantic and in military alliance formation in general. By the 1990s, there was a common perception that NATO had become an outdated and dysfunctional organization, no longer willing or capable of serving a clear purpose due to the demise of the USSR and the end of the Cold War. As late as 2019, French President Emmanuel Macron declared that NATO was experiencing "brain death" (Haglund, 2022). However, this view was proven wrong, as the organization expanded its membership and took on new tasks, some of which were no longer related to defense. Conflicts such as the War in Afghanistan (2001-2021), the 1995 and 1999 interventions in the former Yugoslavia, the 2011 toppling of the Gaddafi regime and, most recently, the ongoing involvement in Ukraine during Russia's Special Military Operation, showcases NATO's expanded remit.

The United States plays a key role in the alliance, as the country is the leading member-state in terms of military expenditure. The USA is consequently frequently perceived as the leader of the alliance and as possessing an agenda-setting role. Bilateral relations of the United States with individual European member states are thus all the more important, and go beyond the transatlantic framework. Franco-American relations are of particular significance. In addition to possessing continental Europe's largest

army, France is the oldest ally of the United States, having maintained friendly relations with the country since the founding days of the American War for Independence. France was the first country to officially recognize US statehood, and Franco-American relations thus have deep historical roots. France is also frequently cited as a main engine for contemporary European integration, including in the realm of defense policy, affecting its engagement with the perennial transatlantic ally.

In parallel with developments related to the European integration process, the United States has shifted its indulgent approach towards NATO and the alliances with its transatlantic partners to a more assertive one, with the transition beginning under the presidency of Donald Trump. The USA demanded that its European allies increase their defense spending in order to meet an agreed upon 2 percent of GDP. Despite the different tone and style of the succeeding Biden administration, the insistence on the greater participation of other states into the common defense budget was maintained and further accentuated. Currently, a number of NATO countries still do not fulfill the essential military expenditure requirements, with France at 2.06% barely meeting the threshold in 2024. Recent years have nonetheless seen a steady increase in defense spending among NATO members, with the number of countries meeting the minimum requirement soaring from 4 members in 2017 to 23 members in 2024 (with the total membership standing at 32 states as of 2024) (Duggal, 2024).

It is thus interesting to investigate what prompted such a change of pattern in expenditures over the preceding decade or so, and in particular whether US rhetoric and foreign policy change on the matter precipitated the increase. In this regard, an analysis of Franco-American relations over the period presents itself as a meaningful case-study, taking into account not only the historical ties between the two nations and the current significance of the

French military within the NATO framework, but also the tendency of France to pursue independent defense policies and attempt to foster European (as opposed to transatlantic) cooperation. These dynamics are all the more relevant, considering the return of Donald Trump to the White House in January 2025. Trump's attitude towards the alliance during the first months of his second mandate has proven even more confrontational than before, severely straining transatlantic ties and prompting open speculation in Europe on the future viability of NATO as a security framework. As a number of European states have embarked on ambitious rearmament programs to mitigate the impact of a potential departure of the USA from the alliance, France has been forefront in coordinating efforts to strengthen European defense and rally support for Ukraine. This is observed most evidently in the so-called 'coalition of the willing' that has been spearheaded by Emmanuel Macron and British PM Keir Starmer (Bortoletto, 2025). Taking into account the degree to which the United States has become an unreliable partner to Europe, the role assumed by France has wider implications for the whole continent, including Russia. Due to the relative size and strength possessed by France, the country will manifestly be a centerpiece of any attempt to redesign the European security system. Consequently, a study of US-French relations over a longer period of time that can highlight the primary motivations and directions in the countries' defense policy would allow to achieve a better understanding of current issues affecting the wider region of Europe and the North Atlantic.

Literature review

A significant amount of scholarly attention has been devoted to various aspects of transatlantic exchange and partnership. Bilateral relations, including

Franco-American interactions, have been studied in detail. Taking into account the particular relationship of the United States and France, among the longest-standing bilateral relations between sovereign states in modern history, it comes as no surprise that there is a rich literature exploring various aspects of US-French exchange and cooperation in a variety of fields. Of paramount interest to this research paper is collaboration in the military sphere. The historical context of the Cold War had a major impact, and thus US-French interactions within NATO structures have been a focal point of earlier studies.

France's outlook on NATO has been marked by the decision of President Charles de Gaulle to withdraw the country entirely from the integrated command structure of the organization in 1966. France only fully returned to NATO structures in 2009 under Nicolas Sarkozy's presidency. Consequently, a number of studies analyze relations during this unusual period of 'incomplete' membership. Falk Ostermann (2018) examines how the construction of French national identity evolved within the organization and the boundaries set by the transatlantic partnership in general. The author highlights how interactions between the European Union, NATO and Franco-American bilateral bonds combined to form a new French approach to security policy. The French foreign policy identity was described using Interpretive Policy Analysis and discourse theory from the Essex School. Above all, it can be shown that France in the 2000s progressively rejected the alternatives presented by increasingly deeper cooperation within the EU to the benefit of reintegration with NATO, which was achieved towards the end of the decade. Chirac's unsuccessful attempt to accomplish the same in the 1990s, as well as the major impact of the intervention in Libya in 2011 are also considered for a holistic understanding of the evolution of France-NATO relations. Overall, France de-unionized and atlanticized its defense policy in

the new millennium, becoming increasingly reliant on the United States for efficient foreign policy implementation.

Such patterns of change are similarly studied by Bozo and Parmentier (2019), but the scope of the research is narrower, focusing on a key period of the early 2000s, during which Franco-American relations appeared to deteriorate under the tensions caused by the US invasion of Iraq in 2003. The unprecedented move by the United States was widely condemned in France, severely straining cooperation. Nonetheless, the authors underscore that bilateral relations saw some improvement in 2004, and that it has been characterized by a "businesslike" spirit and pragmatic approach from both sides since then. The two countries are complementary partners when common interests are identified and notions of national grandeur are abandoned in favor of concrete objectives.

In a study by Pannier (2017), the idea of French "exceptionalism" which permeates the French political elite is also foregrounded as a significant element underpinning policy choices in the realm of defense and armament. Similar to Ostermann (2018), Pannier underscores the historical sources of the French identity, rooted in the political philosophy of De Gaulle. His study traces the evolution of French defense policy as seen in contrast with that of the United States and Great Britain. While the three Allies engaged in close-knit cooperation during the Second World War and at the onset of the Cold War, the relation quickly soured under the influence of the autonomous stance adopted by De Gaulle in the 1960s, as well as the failed French participation in the Second Arab-Israeli war of 1956. The UK had for long been the 'significant other' of France in terms of identity-building and thus the disruption was of lesser significance, but US-French partnership suffered notably during this period. Nonetheless, harmonization occurred after the collapse of the USSR. The author examines policy adjustments in three areas:

discourses, institutional commitments and modes of action, and shows that there has been a noteworthy realignment between France and the Anglo-Saxon partners in the sphere of common defense.

Other scholars have also studied transatlantic relations in a broader specter, including France in a larger group of states. For instance, Knutsen (2022) takes an interest in the US-EU interplay which, considering the preponderant role taken on by the former in NATO, can partially be substituted with a NATO-EU conceptualization. He employs a neo-functionalist methodology so as to question the implications of a more fragmented transatlantic cooperation for the European system of defense and international security. It is argued that efforts to strengthen European autonomy in the defense sector in later years can be seen as a consequence of lessened American reliability less consistent diplomatic efforts on the part of the United States. Nonetheless, the author cautions against disregarding transatlantic relations as a relic of the past, pointing out that the diverging policy preferences of the EU member states in terms of defense spending and trajectory signify that close cooperation between NATO and any European-wide defense projects will be required. While so doing, the European Union also faces troubling questions about its own identity, as adopting a more active, decisively pro-European position in the now multipolar state system might signal an abandonment of the multilateral principles that has underpinned its work for decades.

The importance of international organizations in framing bilateral relations are also present in the work of Pruchnicka (2022), who investigated France's foreign policy approach to the United States during Emmanuel Macron's first presidential term. She understands the memberships in the United Nations and NATO to be the most decisive in shaping bilateral relations between France and the United States. The notion of power status is

also a substantial factor that helps elucidate France's behavior vis-a-vis its ally across the Atlantic. The power asymmetry between the two countries, given that the USA retained its superpower status after the Cold War, while France following decolonization in the 1950s-1960s in some sense lost its former prestige as a great power, has prompted a commonplace feeling of 'anti-Americanism' among the French political establishment. The French outlook on the United States can therefore be characterized as simultaneous "friendship and hatred". The countries do, however, share some common features in their thinking about the role of great powers in the international system. As such, both the USA and France considered a potential arrangement involving UN peacekeepers in Ukraine with skepticism at the onset of the Special Military Operation in 2022, as both Biden and Macron demonstrated a desire for power politics and felt entitled to play a key role in any settlement process. The opportunities and challenges presented by changes in government in 2017, with Emmanuel Macron and Donald Trump acceding to the presidential office in January and May, respectively, were also highlighted by Belin (2018). In his view, the French approach to international affairs is essentially based on realism, and the affinity displayed by Trump and Macron during their early meetings can be interpreted as the result of more pragmatically aligned foreign policies of the two countries. In this regard, a lessened focus on idealistic politics and interventionism was seen as a welcome shift in Paris. Belin furthermore points out that the election year represented a historical high in US-French relations in the defense sphere, as there had been extensive coordination of defense policies over the previous ten years or so, mostly centered on counterterrorist action and shared operations in Middle Eastern and African theatres. Notwithstanding the synergy and apparent mutual understanding between the newly elected heads of state, the author casts doubts on the perspectives for improved and ever closer partnership, suggesting that Trump's unilateralist instincts and

disregard for multilateral institutions might sap any potential transatlantic concord.

The impact of the changes introduced by the Trump administration, as well as the level of disruption and continuity between the Trump and Biden administrations, have also come under the scrutiny of academics. Kaufman (2017) undertook an analysis of the transatlantic relationship's evolution from a historical perspective, seeking to extract lessons from the past that can assist in predicting future developments, in particular in the light of the election of Donald Trump in 2016. The modifications in policy course that the Trump administration would bring were described as unpredictive and incoherent, with statements made by Trump-appointed officials and by the president-elect himself contradicting each other. The long-standing skepticism to multilateralism displayed by Trump, for instance in his description of NATO as an "obsolete" entity, as well as his declared intention of placing US national interests forefront, warrant some speculations about deatlanticization and a more marked turn among European allies towards the EU as a collective security guarantor. However, the author also underlined that the approach adopted towards a resurgent Russia will exert a significant influence on any adjustments in transatlantic relations. Goldgeier (2019) adopts a similar point of view, expressing reservations about the sense of obligation linking the United States to its European allies under Donald Trump's presidency. The author acknowledges the extent and clout of the deep state acting as a barrier containing the isolationist policies of Trump. The favorable public opinion on NATO in the USA as well as traditional backing by the Congress are other factors that limiting presidential idiosyncrasies. The article nonetheless concludes that the latter two instances may be oscillating under pressure from new political movements and developments that were ushered in by the Republican electoral victory of 2016. Most notably, previously broad political

endorsement of a continued American presence in NATO seems to be reorganizing around partisan lines under the influence of Trump's harshly negative discourse on the topic, with the Democrat party appearing increasingly lone in their continued championing of the organization.

Similar issues are explored by Sperling and Webber (2019), who note Trump's verbal onslaught on the multilateralism that has formed the backbone of the global order since 1945. Unlike Goldgeier, however, the authors argue that the transatlantic relationship is still sound and unlikely to undergo drastic modification in the nearest future. Two years into the Trump administration, they highlight the success of the organization in withstanding the uncertainty caused by the changes in official rhetoric. They attribute the discontent exhibited by the Republican government to a strategy of direct criticism aimed at obtaining leverage within intergovernmental organizations. This approach has been observed for some years, and in that regard Trump does not represent a game-changing turn in US politics. A complete withdrawal from the transatlantic framework is perceived as unlikely by the authors, considering the endurance of the alliance as well as a lack of practical feasibility. This perspective is also expressed by Schreer (2019), who argues that the security complex formed between North America and Europe is a quasi-permanent factor in contemporary international relations. There is consequently little room for any significant rearrangement of the security order, which is marked by the overwhelmingly predominant position occupied by NATO, with supplementary tasks performed by the European Union in its missions abroad as part of the Common Security and Defense Policy (CSDP). The paper also casts doubts on the capacity of the European Union to boost its own strategic autonomy through increased investments in the CSDP and reduced dependence on NATO for military purposes. The European NATO members are mostly content with preserving the status quo of transatlantic cooperation,

and the new US administration is uncapable of structurally undermining it to any meaningful degree.

In a retrospective study, Schuette (2021) maintains the key points stated by previous papers, related to the longevity of the North Atlantic partnership. It is clear that NATO as an organization withstood the troubled presidency of Donald Trump, who neither succeeded in divorcing the United States from it, nor managed to scale down the responsibilities and commitments of the USA inside it. The continued subsistence of the alliance over the four disconcerting years can be attributed to a number of factors, including the ability of the State Secretary bureaucracy in undermining and distorting the White House's policies, the power of a deeply liberal American public, and the backlash surrounding the President's personality and outlandish mannerisms. The single most important element in NATO's success, however, was the effective governance of the organization. Schuette conducted interviews with a number of high-ranking representatives of the defense alliance and concluded that the Secretary General was central to the united front displayed by the other member states, aptly fending off and disarming Trump's unilateralist inclinations. In the author's view, Secretary General Stoltenberg engaged Trump diplomatically and sustained a positive relationship with him, partially placating his demands for increased expenditures by the other member countries. Schuessler and Shifrinson (2019) are also confident that the transatlantic partnership will continue to be a mainstay in American foreign policy, but adopt an entirely different point of view. The authors criticize the perception of Donald Trump as an outlier in the succession of US administrations since 1949, and claim that the caprices and anchoring strategies used by Trump are not unique in the history of the organization. Indeed, previous administrations have also had recourse to menaces, such as those of pulling out of the partnership, as an instrument for the furtherance of

American foreign policy goals. Such stratagems were particularly prevalent in the early history of the Treaty, when the United States seriously considered withdrawing its forces stationed in Europe since the end of World War II, and resurfaced in later stages of the Cold War, as a response to the ever closer cooperation between France and Germany. In other words, US alliances have not been characterized only by confidence building among formally equal partners, but have seen the United States maneuvering deftly so as to retain its central position in the alliance network. Consequently, in the view of the authors, Trump's presidency is unlikely to permanently undermine the cooperation between the United States and its European allies.

Points of convergence and divergence between the Trump and Biden administrations are explored by Singh (2024), who defines the contrasting foreign policies of the latest two US Presidents as "doctrines", a term in line with the naming tradition established during the Cold War and continued in the 21st century with the 'Bush doctrine'. The Biden administration's approach to foreign policy was from the onset marked by the desire to distance itself from that of Donald Trump and signify a return to the bipartisan internationalist tradition established by earlier administrations. The author, however, questions the extent to which Biden succeeded in renewing US commitment to its allies and a global rules-based order defined by active and unwavering participation in international forums and institutions, such as NATO. First, a series of foreign policy misfortunes, most notably the calamitous retreat from Afghanistan in 2021, sapped trust in the US ability to prevail globally. Second, the vagueness of Biden's strategy, being variously classified with epithets such as "Rooseveltian internationalism", "belligerent nationalism" and even "pragmatic realism", fostered uncertainty among allies. Third, the points of continuity with the Trump administration undermined Biden's self-constructed image as an 'anti-Trump'. The author concludes that

Biden leaves behind a legacy of mixed accomplishments. In an article that serves as an introduction to a lengthier journal special edition on the Biden administration and the challenges and opportunities it faces, Dimitrova (2022) similarly underlines the efforts made by Biden to resuscitate the transatlantic partnership after the alleged damage caused by Donald Trump's four years in power. In many ways the Democratic Party's return to the White House generated enthusiasm in Europe, with expectations that US foreign policy towards its allies would become more predictable hereafter. Whereas other scholars showed to the resilience of NATO during Trump's presidency, Dimitrova underscores that his mandate in general terms represented an all-time low in the transatlantic relationship, due to a focus on internal policy issues marked by slogans such as "America First" and "Make America Great Again" (MAGA). Collective security and multilateralism were never a great concern for the Republicans, at least not for the Trumpist faction that dominated party politics in 2017-2021.

Some of these reflections are echoed in Sheng (2023), though he broadens the scope of Trumpian policies that could be considered calamitous for the transatlantic partnership. Beyond the general onslaught on multilateral institutions, Trump employed a dismissive rhetoric vis-a-vis the EU specifically, raising doubts about the future of trade and economic agreements between the two sides of the Atlantic. Additional factors that contributed to the plummeting of relations was the incoherent response of the Trump administration to the COVID-19 pandemic, as well as a pivot from the Atlantic basin to the Indo-Pacific, epitomized by the American trade war with China. The inauguration of Joe Biden in January 2021 reversed this trend, though the approach of the new administration is largely one of instrumentality. The author gives much attention to the emergence of competing poles in the international system and the rise of China in particular.

In his view, transatlantic relations can be mobilized as a tool so as to prop up the American strategy of containment of its two principal adversaries, China and the Russian federation. However, this scheme faces some difficulties in the political fragmentation of Europe, as European states have differing preferences regarding their relations with both Russia and China. For instance, several southern European state have engaged China or expressed a willingness to take part in the Belt and Road Initiative. Another hurdle that complicates the matter is the US attempt to increase the presence of NATO in the Indo-Pacific and South China Sea with a view to deter Chinese expansionism in the region. This poses a dilemma for many member states who are also part of the European Union, which cultivates close commercial ties with the People's Republic of China.

Besides the escalating tensions and great power competition between China and the United States, much attention has been devoted to the standoff between the USA and Russia during Biden's presidency, and the implications for the former's role in the transatlantic alliance. Thus, according to Dolan (2023), the American involvement in the conflict in Ukraine from 2022 onwards has exerted a defining influence on the way in which the United States understands its position and responsibilities within the organization. The effect has been ambiguous and has evolved in unexpected directions since the beginning of the Special Military Operation. The author notes the rising popularity of dissenting voices in domestic US politics, who question the need for an American obligation to uphold European security. These unprecedented reservations about the validity of a continued NATO cooperation can be seen in parallel with an emerging awareness of China as the United States' primary rival on the world stage. Party dynamics and the desire for Republicans and Democrats to distance themselves from each other have also been a prominent factor underlying the drift away from Europe. This perspective is shared by

McNamara (2022), who underscores the challenges that a changed geopolitical reality imposes on the formation of alliances between the USA and smaller countries. In that regard, the evolution of the conflict in Ukraine highlights some essential features of US alliance building and their (potential lack of) sustainability. Many smaller states around the globe are confronted with the choice between promoting ties with the United States and managing relations with neighboring revisionist powers that are eager to carve out a more distinguished place for themselves in the international system. The author predicts that the American leadership, despite a period of more inward focus under Donald Trump, will probably continue to cultivate a set of informal alliances and partnerships with a varied selection of countries, as it sees fit. Less emphasis will be placed on formal alliances, such as NATO.

The differences and similarities between the presidencies of Trump and Biden were also explored by Bag, Roy, & Shah (2024), who used a 'national role conception theory' in order to clarify the degree of variation in policies related to foreign relations and security matters. They take interest in the cognition of the head of state and interrogate to what extent the way in which the two leaders conceptualized the position, duties and part to be played by the USA impacted on the way they construed their alliances, and in particular on cooperation within the NATO framework. The team of researchers found that while there were mostly dissimilarities between the perceptions of Trump and Biden, there was an important share of correspondence, which can explain the presence of overlapping policy visions. Their highly contrasting handlings of NATO are also partly accounted for by the differences in national role perception. Miskimmon et al. (2023), on the other hand, employed the concept of 'strategic narratives' to reconcile the fields of Foreign Policy Analysis and mainstream International Relations theory. This approach highlights how specific policies are being legitimized, both to the domestic public and to the

outside world. Again, the notion of national identity is central to any understanding of the decision-making process. The author found that Trump's rhetoric represented a rupture in US foreign policy tradition, as it was mostly employing a commercial language with philosophical underpinnings situated in the tradition of mercantilism. The Trumpist vision was directly at odds with the narrative that predominated in the European NATO members, which was rooted in a shared tradition of compromise and coaction, and implicitly understood the existence of NATO and other multilateral forums as normatively desirable. The paper predicts that the aftershocks of Trump's mandate will last some time, but that any subsequent US administrations can benefit from returning to a common, transatlantic narrative centered on democratic government, liberalism and shared cultural values.

There is also a dense body of academic work on French defense and security outlooks. Frequent topics that come up in relation to French strategy-making in recent years include the relationship of the country with other states (above all the United States, Germany and Russia), the impact of terrorism and Brexit on French policy orientations, as well as the ambiguous role played by France in balancing NATO with a prospective integrated European defense project.

Pannier and Schmitt (2019) provide an overview on French defense outlooks in the 2010s. They note that French policy-making has undergone considerable changes over the last decade in terms of how it reflects on the use of military force. As a result of reduced economic means and a changed landscape of threats, French defense policy has contracted so as to concentrate on a smaller portfolio of tasks. In particular, terrorism emerged as a significant menace to national security half-way through the decade, contributing to the prioritization of combat operations in the Sahel and in the Middle East (Syria). With the rise of competing great powers, typically identified as Russia, Iran or

China, but sometimes including Erdogan's Turkey in the list, the limits of the French military have become more apparent, and with it the need to engage allies in collective structures. In this sense, French policy has become increasingly realist in nature. At the same time, there is continuity with the past, as France perpetuates an old aim of projecting itself as an active player in the international system, capable of projecting power way beyond the confines of its territory (Pannier & Schmitt, 2019). An important aspect of French defense policy is necessarily its somewhat troubled relations with NATO, of which it is a founding member, but whose integrated command structure it opted to remain outside of for an extended period of time. The relation is outlined by Grand (2024) in a paper that takes a retrospective glance on seventy-five years of French NATO membership. Common misperceptions about France's position within the organization are that the country is vehemently opposed to the alliance, or on the contrary, that it acts like a puppet deprived of autonomy. In reality, the French political elite have long attempted to find an equilibrium between these to extremes. Still, the French trajectory within the North Atlantic format is unique for at least two reasons. First, the country takes great concern with perpetuating its influence in former colonies and protectorates, especially in West Africa and the Greater Middle East. Second, France is one of only three member states of NATO (the other two being the United States and Turkey) to have developed its military essentially in an autonomous fashion, founded on domestic incentives. These features set it apart among other European countries, which pursue a more customary, 'Atlanticist' defense policy.

A considerable amount of research has been dedicated to the prospects of a common European defense system or organization, and the potential position that France would occupy in this novel entity. As noted by Guseinov (2020), France has in recent years, under the leadership of Emmanuel Macron,

become a champion of a common European defense, usually understood to evolve within the already existing EU framework, the Common Security and Defense Policy (CSDP). At its current state, the military and security sphere is the least integrated of all European Union policy areas. Guseinov studied the motivating incentives that help explain the shift in French policy-making, as France now appears as the foremost promoter of European integration. As argued by the author, the political ideology espoused by Macron is akin to a "flexible Gaullism", assuming the heritage of the first President of the Fifth Republic. The principle concretization of Macron's outward-looking policies has been the Permanent Structured Cooperation (PESCO), in which French collaboration with Germany has so far been paramount to furthering the cause of European military integration. Staunton (2022) expands upon these themes, and studied how Macron conceptualizes his Europeanizing mission through the prism of civilization. Through a comparison of over two hundred pieces of discourse made by Macron over the course of his first presidential mandate, Staunton foregrounds how Macron perceives France as having a historic mission to defend both the liberal international order and European civilization as a distinct entity within this global order. The conclusion is remarkable, considering that the two notions at first glance appear contradictory. It also shows the commitment of France, as a middle power or lesser great power, to international organizations and multilateral solutions. Maślanka (2023) takes on a more negative view of Macron's maneuvering on the international arena, arguing that by distancing himself from NATO and the partnership with the United States, the French President is effectively weaking the degree of trust his country so far has enjoyed, both globally and among other allies. Despite vowing support for the Ukrainian war effort since 2022, the Macronian project of a united Europe that is more autonomous from the USA has been advocated for through the use of terms such as 'balance of power', 'sphere of influence' and a framing of European civilization that is

reminiscent of the notion of multipolarity. This, in the opinion of the author, has brought France ideologically closer to more authoritarian states that construct their identity and role by relying on similar notions. The French stated desire of attaining more independence from the United States, both for itself and for its European neighbors, is also noted by Tekir (2021), who reconnects the debate to the uncertainties surrounding the continued validity of NATO. The progressive decoupling between North America and Europe observed in the late 2010s are to be attributed to two parallel developments: the radical turn in American foreign policy under Donald Trump, as well as the rise of a more assertive European Union, increasingly acting more as a whole than as a sum of its components. Illustrations of the latter include the aforementioned PESCO, but also the EI2 (European Intervention Initiative), which is not attached to an EU organ, but functions independently. The EI2 was first proposed by Macron, and is headquartered in Paris. Notwithstanding the limited scope of these projects compared to NATO, they symbolize the European effort to achieve greater autonomy that is being spearheaded by France. Macron has so far been reasonably successful in fusioning France's foreign policy objectives with those of the wider region. Some scholars nonetheless comment on the lack of unity that beleaguers attempts at integrating the European continent into a common and coherent defense system. Like Guseinov, Wasson (2024) points out the Gaullist tradition that permeates French endeavors to realign collective security agreements away from the United States. The concept of Europe puissance, first advanced by De Gaulle, is central to France's European policy - the idea that European nations together can form a common army that will enable the continent to compete with great powers such as the United States, Russia, and now China. Two major stumbling blocks for the European project, however, have been the decision of the UK to leave the EU in 2016, as well as less cordial French-German bilateral relations. In effect, the French strife for European

leadership has been poorly received by the German political establishment, both under Merkel and Scholtz.

Brexit is in the academic literature commonly perceived as a starting point for renewed European integration initiatives, for instance in Koenig and Walter-Franke (2017). More importantly, though, the degree of synergy between France and Germany in promoting or hindering European integration in the defense sphere has received much scholarly attention since the downsizing of the Union in 2016. Thus, Koenig and Walter-Franke argue that both countries have invested themselves in the CSDP since the UK's withdrawal, but question the extent to which the two partners will manage to find common ground in the concrete policies to be implemented, and whether the Franco-German tandem in itself is adequate to serve as a locomotive for reform in the EU. Kempin (2021) underscores the gap that separates the French and German visions of the Common Security and Defense Policy. In light of a diminished American presence and attentiveness to European security, France is eager to replace the United States as a guarantor of continental peace and stability. Despite such ambitious aims, the French government under Emmanuel Macron has come to the realization that it does not possess the necessary capabilities by itself, and has turned to its German neighbor in the hopes of attracting German funds and clout. Germany, however, has so far been reticent to French blueprints for tighter cooperation, preferring to balance its commitments to the EU and NATO instead. Billon-Galland and Quencez (2017) view the integration process less despondently, maintaining that while there may be significant divergence in the French and German outlooks on security and the strategy to pursue for a common European military in the long term, convergence between the two states is possible in a shorter to medium term. Crucially, it will depend on the willingness of French and German governments to overcome differences that

relate to the specific adoption and implementation of policies. These include disagreements of technical nature, such as what sort of projects to promote within the Permanent Structured Cooperation. The Franco-German disharmony of opinion is also studied by Rynning (2017) in a longer perspective. He contends that the sources of differing perspectives on NATO can be traced to the Harmel Report of 1967, during the production of which the French and German distinct attitudes to the political component of NATO appeared. While France was initially skeptical of an enhanced political dimension for NATO, West Germany adopted a more nuanced stance. This split is still present in contemporary attempts to reconcile integration within the EU framework, which for long has been driven by a fundamentally economic logic, with integration through NATO, which has a military and security rationale.

Finally, a subset of academic papers focus on developments in Franco-Russian relations over the past decade so as to elucidate changes in French defense postures. Belgacem (2021) contends that French foreign policy has become more realist with the return of Russia as a great power capable of fashioning the European international security system to its advantage. Emmanuel Macron's dismissive declarations about NATO can be seen in connection with his venture at engaging Russia's President Vladimir Putin in the late 2010s and early 2020s. It could be argued that Russia's rise since the 2014 reunification of Crimea with the mainland and successful Russian interventions in the Middle East and Sahel have had a disruptive effect on French attitudes to NATO, with the political elite now exploring viable alternatives. Attempts at rapprochement stalled, however, after the 2022 escalation of the Ukrainian conflict. Welc (2023) remarks that the events of 2022 forced significant shifts in French foreign policy alignments, often to the benefit of France. The importance of France in NATO and to the

Americans was considered to have risen as a result of the latter's commitment to supply the Ukrainians with equipment and weaponry. Of greater consequence, however, is the traction gained by the common European defense project, of which Macron has been a staunch supporter for years. France adopted, in the initial phase of the conflict, a less bellicose approach than other European states, and have actively developed ties with other actors in the international system with a more neutral position, most notably the countries in the Persian Gulf. Lastly, the devastation of the German economy that has resulted from the Ukrainian crisis and the German leadership's decision to reorient energy supplies away from Russia, can also be seen to France's advantage, as it has consolidated the relative position of the latter in the European Union. France thus appears progressively more self-assertive and outspoken against this backdrop of German weakness. Another, and somewhat unexpected foreign policy development since 2022 has been the confluence between France and Central European states such as Poland and the Czech Republic, as indicated by Cadier (2024). Central and Eastern Europe have conventionally been poles apart from France in debates of the shared European security system, with the former placing strong emphasis on an American presence in Europe and displaying limited interest in a purely European defense solution. However, as a result of the uncertainties brought by the conflict in Ukraine, Cadier argues there has been a slight softening in the position of Central European countries towards the prospect of an integrated European military.

A few general remarks can be derived from the literature review above. First, the academic literature on Joseph Biden's presidency is less developed than that on Donald Trump's first period, which is reasonable, considering that Biden quite recently ended his mandate and studies are often years in the making. Second, there is a dense literature on US policies towards NATO

(and to some extent the EU), but not so much has been written about American policies towards specific member states of NATO and/or the EU. Third, academic research on US-French relations in the defense sector mostly focus on NATO and mostly carries a historical perspective - they are often centered on the origins of the organization and the impact of Charles de Gaulle, with some articles exploring more recent governments, such as the Chirac, Sarkozy and Hollande presidencies seen in relation to the Bush and Obama administrations. There is, however, little scholarship on the most recent presidencies, that is, on interactions between Macron on the one hand, and Trump and Biden on the other. And fourth, recent studies on French defense and security policy is overwhelmingly concerned with the French push for a shared and integrated European defense structure.

Research gap

Thus, while a number of articles and works discuss the evolution of Franco-American relations, French policy towards NATO and changes brought by the Trump and Biden administrations to transatlantic cooperation, no one study attempted to comprehensively examine the influence of US foreign policy on French defense policy during the leadership of Emmanuel Macron. There is thus a clear research gap to be explored, which is best done through a neoclassical realist prism, allowing to consider both external and domestic factors that affect the policy-making process. This topic should consequently be covered in detail so as to fill the existing gap in the academic literature. Over the course of this research paper, I will attempt to elucidate the possible linkages between US and French policies, and draw lessons for future developments in the area. The topic is all the more relevant as the changes initiated by Trump in 2017 have acquired renewed significance with the re-election of the latter to the US presidency in late 2024.

Research question and hypothesis

The research question will be the following: *How did US policy, including towards NATO, under Trump and Biden affect French defense policy in 2017-2025?* French defense policy takes on multiple dimensions: its commitment to NATO budget requirements and its positioning within NATO structures, but also its role in promoting European alternatives to NATO such as the Permanent Structured Cooperation, as well as its claimed status as a military great power and independent actor in world affairs. A preliminary hypothesis could be that the inconsistent tone of the last two US presidential administrations interacted with domestic political factors in France to produce equivalent variations in French policy, giving stimuli both to continued close cooperation and coordination with the American partner, such as within the existing framework of NATO, and to the pursuit of a more independent defense policy that promotes the development of joint European defense projects.

Methodology

This research paper will be a case-study. As such, it will have a rather narrow focus on bilateral Franco-American relations, though any findings could have wider implications for other NATO members as well. The examined period is 2017-2025, corresponding both to the ongoing presidency of Emmanuel Macron, and to the entire duration of the first Trump administration and the Biden administration.

The study is inscribed into a neoclassical realist framework. A realist approach is appropriate to highlight security considerations and power

calculations made by the concerned actors, especially taking into account the topic of the paper, as defense policy and changes in the balance of military power is a highly securitized area of international affairs. This is all the more true as regards the Trump administration, which not only in practice, but also in rhetoric marked a step away from conventional American discourse, which tends to be infused with liberal viewpoints, towards a neorealist perspective.

However, a neorealist framework would not be sufficient to elucidate fluctuations in French policy-making, neither in the long term of post-war relations, nor in the more compressed time frame of this paper. In effect, France's foreign policy has been governed by two contradictory traditions - one Atlanticist, seeking tight cooperation and alliance with the United States, the other more independent, pursuing the objective of strategic autonomy. In realist parlance, France has responded to US superpower status both by bandwagoning and by soft-balancing, varying its approach as it saw fit. At times France sees itself as subordinate to the United States, at other times as coordinate to the USA.

Therefore, a theoretical framework grounded in neoclassical realism would be better fit for this topic. Neoclassical realism interprets foreign policy as the product of a broader set of factors. In addition to the structure of the international system, aspects of domestic politics, such as public opinion, perception of national identity, and the contribution of specific leaders are incorporated (Rose, 1998). Consequently, this research paper will employ neoclassical realism in order to cover not only the systemic pressures represented by the United States and the power differential between the two countries, but also the domestic factors internal to France that allow to clarify the variation observed in French strategic posturing.

This paper will mainly rely on the methods of comparative historical research, process tracing and the narrative method to research the chosen topic. Comparative historical research builds on the study of historical events to expound modifications in political processes. It allows to identify crucial factors and root causes that account for the observed changes, and is therefore particularly pertinent for the analysis of time periods characterized by policy shifts and variation. The method is quite suitable for the topic of international security in the 2010s and early 2020s, considering the high density of events and subsequent policy reorientations in that period.

In addition to comparative historical research, process tracing will be used to understand how modifications in the US approach to NATO may have translated into adjustments in French defense policy through a step-by-step analysis. Process tracing is a "systematic examination" of evidence that is "selected and analyzed in light of research questions and hypotheses posed by the investigator" (Collier, 2011). A careful description of how events unfolded throughout the period will help foreground causal processes. Process tracing is a relevant choice of method for the present topic, as it is suitable for the identification of new political phenomena and making inferences based on data which does not easily lend itself to conventional means of analysis, such as regression.

Finally, the narrative method will complement any findings by examining the main ideas and patterns of documents. A careful analysis will be undertaken by highlighting key words in the relevant texts.

1. Brief overview of US-French military cooperation over time

1.1 US-French Military Relations in the Cold War (1945-1991)

The defense relationship between France and the United States developed significantly in the 1900s, due to such events as the two World Wars and the ensuing Cold War. In historical retrospect, the United States progressively abandoned its isolationist stance in a transitionary period spanning the World Wars and the interwar years. After a period of American retreat from world affairs in the 1920s and 1930s, military cooperation became far more extensive from 1941 onwards, when the United States entered World War II on the side of the Allies and embarked on an enormous rearmament strategy. The USA provided aid to France through the Lend-Lease program, and liberated the country from German occupation over the summer of 1944. Cooperation also tightened with a system of shared control over defeated Germany through the Allied Control Council, in which France, the United States and Great Britain each administered their zone of Germany (Ziemke, 1975). Moreover, in 1949, France and the United States were among the founding members of a new collective security alliance, the North Atlantic Treaty Organization. There were some frictions during the war, as the Roosevelt administration was not particularly fond of General Charles de Gaulle, who was leading a French government in exile (Statler, 2023). The latter's obstinate character would cause a deeper rift in US-French relations in the post-war period, culminating in France's decision to leave the integrated command structure of NATO in 1966 (though still remaining a treaty member). The headquarters of the organization were initially located at the outskirts of Paris, but were moved to Brussels the following year as a result of the French departure (France Channel, 2024; NATO, 2024a). France also independently developed its own nuclear weapons program in 1960 (Nuclear Threat Initiative, 2025).

In general terms, the foreign policy priorities of France, which was an imperial power in severe decline, differed significantly from those of the United States, a rising superpower ideologically and rhetorically opposed to colonialism. The two countries also differed in their approach to the management of West Germany in the post-war years. This prompted France to pursue a line of action that was more autonomous from the United States, in particular compared to the UK, which to a much greater extent fused its foreign policy with that of the USA and developed the so-called 'special relationship' (Hein, 2002). Besides NATO, other points of disagreement in the area of defense policy included the Vietnam War and the 1956 Suez Crisis. De Gaulle opposed American intervention into the former French colony of Indochina, while the United States condemned the so-called Tripartite aggression against Egypt and the Suez Canal, in which France participated. The 1950s and 1960s therefore proved to be a rather tumultuous period in US-French relations, despite increased military, economic and political coordination. After the end of decolonization and De Gaulle's definitive retreat from politics in 1968, however, relations between the two states smoothed out, anchored in the common interest of countering and deterring the Soviet Union (Statler, 2016).

1.2 Post-Cold War Realignment (1991-2017)

Following the end of the Cold War in 1991, a new age of US-French military cooperation began. France did not accommodate rapidly to the changed security environment that the dissolution of the Warsaw Pact represented. Relations between France and the United States improved over the 1990s under the presidencies of François Mitterrand and Bill Clinton, as the latter viewed an enhanced European component in NATO more positively

than previous American administrations. It should be noted that France at that point in time was championing European integration - the European Commission President was French Jacques Delors, who decisively contributed to the creation of the single market and the signing of the 1992 Maastricht Treaty. Under Clinton, the notion of Combined Joint Task Forces was incorporated into NATO in order to address unconventional security issues, and was partly a response to the unfolding civil war in the former Yugoslavia. It satisfied to some degree the French desire for a more autonomous European defense (Sloan, 1997), though any further realignment of France with NATO would only occur a decade later. Another major problem was the ineffectiveness of the French armed forces, which had become apparent during the 1990-1991 Gulf War, and which, together with budget constraints, incited Jacques Chirac to undertake a series of reforms in the late 1990s. The nuclear triad was reduced by abolishing the country's intercontinental ballistic missile capabilities, leaving only strategic aircraft bombers and submarine-launched missiles. Conventional forces were also reformed and reduced so as to focus on more compact, adaptable and versatile units (ibid.).

The so-called unipolar moment of the United States created such a big power differential between the USA and all other states that France was forced to reconsider its relations to the American giant. By the 2000s, French dissatisfaction with what they perceived as an excessively preponderant role of the USA in international affairs led them to attempt a sort of rebalancing against the USA, albeit only a rhetorical one. The European integration process, which reached its peak in the early 2000s, gave new steam to the idea of European autonomy from the United States, and a number of French politicians supported the advent of a multipolar world order that could replace the unipolar one, which they deeply resented due to the perception that France was being sidelined by the Americans. If multipolarity came to be, it was

reasoned, France could play a more prominent role internationally as part of a European pole. These musings would, however, have few practical consequences (Schmitt, 2017), as other European Union states, in particular the new members of the former socialist block, continued to favor NATO as the foremost security structure for the continent.

The overarching trend in the period after 1991 is therefore the gradual realization of the French political leadership that the country is incapable not only of facing new security challenges on its own, but even in concert with its European neighbors (Sloan, 1997). This explains the rapprochement witnessed between the United States and France, which led France to rejoin NATO's integrated command structure in 2009 under Nicolas Sarkozy. French participation in a number of US-led initiatives and ongoing operations grew following the return to NATO's central command. For instance, Sarkozy chose to boost the French presence in Afghanistan, a move that was welcomed by the Obama administration (Schmitt, 2017). France also became, along with the UK, the most important ally in Syria after the United States by the mid-2010s espoused a policy of gradually deeper intervention into the civil war.

There is still a strong Gaullist political undercurrent in the country that impels it to pursue autonomous foreign policy on defense matters, most evidently observed in 2003 with the French refusal to assist the USA in its unsanctioned invasion of Saddam Hussein's Iraq. Still, US-French cooperation in military matters has expanded, for instance to counter terrorist threats in the post-9/11 era (Bureau of Political-Military Affairs, 2025). In that regard, France's increased military presence in the Sahel region, such as its extended intervention in Mali, was praised in Washington, D.C. Whereas American policymakers at the start of the new millennium took a dim view of what they saw as French uncooperativeness, they had by the middle of the

next decade come to see France as one of their most reliable partners. Thus, by the time Emmanuel Macron and Donald Trump entered office as presidents of France and the USA, respectively, the former country had become much more solidly embedded in the transatlantic framework than was previously the case (Schmitt, 2017).

2. The Impact of US Policy on French Defense Policy

2.1 Presidency of Donald Trump (2017-2021)

On January 20th, 2017, Donald Trump was inaugurated as the 45th President of the United States, being handed over the presidential powers by the Democrat government of Barack Obama. The ensuing four years would in more than one way prove to be an anomaly in American political life. The blunt rhetoric and unconventional campaign employed by the Republican candidate, involving a bypassing of traditional media houses through the use of social media like X (formerly Twitter), sparked controversy on both sides of the main fault line in US politics. Trump represented a significant shift in the way politics was conducted, not only in relation to the Democratic Party he competed against, but also seen in the context of the Republican Party he had integrated, and whose long-standing conventions and stances on a number of issues were upturned by the arrival of what was at the time largely perceived as an outsider. It could be argued that in no other policy area was this more manifest than in that of foreign policy.

While Trump expressed unorthodox views on a host of topics such as the economy, trade and tariffs, women and minority rights, immigration, climate change and national healthcare, his most far-reaching contributions were arguably in the realm of foreign policy. The President upset conventions, both in his treatment of time-hallowed allies as well as his outreach to foreign leaders and states typically understood to be rivals of the United States, such as North Korea, Russia and Iran. Collectively, this produced a paradigmatic rearrangement of international affairs, with ripple effects to the present day. The advent of the first Trump administration in 2017, taken together with the decision of the UK to leave the European Union in 2016, the events in Ukraine in 2014, and the general rise of a more assertive China, is frequently

cited by scholars as ushering in a multipolar world order, putting a decisive end to the so-called unipolar moment of the United States (Wyne, 2019).

Key words to the foreign policy of Donald Trump include the trade war with China, an attempted defrosting of US-Russian relations, the withdrawal from the Iran nuclear deal, multiple head-to-head meetings with North Korean leader Kim Jong Un, the Syrian Civil War, and contestation of American presence in Europe (as well as among allies in East Asia). In all of these areas the approach adopted by the Republican leader constituted a pronounced rupture with previous administrations, most notably with the Obama presidency that immediately preceded him.

Overview of the main foreign policy directions and aspirations

The principal document laying out the guidelines for Donald Trump's foreign policy is the 2017 National Security Strategy, a policy document which is published by the White House at irregular intervals since 2002. It was published in December 2017, roughly one year into the presidency, and is the only National Security Strategy (NSS) released by the Trump administration. It follows the previous NSS, presented by Obama in February 2015, which in turn had updated an earlier NSS made publicly available in 2010. For analytical purposes the frequencies of keywords in the different NSS's have been counted using tools provided by Microsoft Office (see Appendix, Table 1).

A comparison of the 2015 and 2017 strategies makes it abundantly clear that the global outlooks of Donald Trump are consistently different from those of Barack Obama. Trump distances himself markedly from Obama in the way he conceptualizes the international environment within which the United States operates. Obama, though giving attention to some global issues that

pitted the United States against foreign countries, in large part emphasized the collective nature of many tasks faced by the USA, arguing that cooperation and partnership with allies and non-allies alike were paramount if the country was to rise to the challenge (Obama, 2015). In that sense, Obama was rhetorically closer to the International Relations school of liberal internationalism. Trump's NSS, on the other hand, takes an unmistakably realist turn, evident in the opening of the third subsection, titled "Preserve Peace Through Strength": "A central continuity in history is the contest for power. The present time period is no different." (Trump, 2017). He goes on to broadly criticize US politics in the post-Cold War era centered on multilateral institutions and engagement of authoritarian states, for instance the opening up of the international trade regime to China, describing this strategy as ill-advised and "complacent" (ibid.). Trump thus reinstated great power contest, largely dismissed by previous post-1991 presidents, back on the foreign policy agenda in a front and center position, visualizing contemporary international relations as an arena of fierce competition, even among allies. It is telling that the words 'competition', 'competitor', 'competitive' and other words of the same root are used 57 times in the 2017 NSS, but only 10 times in the 2015 version of the document. Simultaneously, less emphasis is placed on normative values, with the use of the terms 'democracy' and 'democratic' scaled back from 45 mentions in the 2015 NSS to 28 mentions in the 2017 NSS. The role to be played by the United States in such a world is necessarily also reevaluated by Trump. While preceding administrations, including the two Obama cabinets, to a greater extent had underscored cooperation and international solidarity as the way forward, as well as the foundational importance of alliances and partnerships, Trump recentered foreign policy around his 'America First' slogan. The frequent use of the term 'homeland' throughout the 2017 NSS is remarkable in this regard, as most foreign policy objectives, whether military, security-related, economic or other are defined in

relation to the promotion of the 'homeland'. Consequently, with the first presidency of Donald Trump there is a certain transition in foreign policy, which goes from being quite outwards-looking to becoming inwards-looking to an extent vaguely reminiscent of the posture adopted by the United States in the interwar period. Still, the changes do not warrant the labeling of a return to pre-war isolationism, as the United States continued to be actively engaged in a number of foreign theatres and regions over the period 2017-2021.

There is also an unequivocal departure from Obama in the assessment of the threat environment confronting the United States. Donald Trump painted a far more hostile picture of the outside world. For instance, the words 'threat' and 'threaten' are mentioned 53 times by Obama in 2015, but over twice as often by Trump in 2017, at 110. The latter identifies three major perils to US security.

First, attacks by international terrorist organizations, such as ISIS and Al-Qaeda, put societies all around the world at risk of destabilization. Though the specific jihadist organizations are given an equal amount of attention by the two presidents (11 and 12 mentions of ISIS by Obama and Trump, respectively, 9 mentions each for Al-Qaeda), one notes that Trump brings up the issue of 'terrorists' and 'terrorism' much more frequently (70 instances) than Obama (37 instances). The ongoing civil war in Syria is briefly mentioned once by Obama, and 6 times by Trump, though this is in line with the evolution of the conflict, as American intervention into the country escalated only after Trump was sworn in as president. A major incentive for US involvement in Syria was to combat the Islamic State which had taken root there.

Second, Trump points to rogue states as a permanent danger for the United States, singling out Iran and North Korea as the most prominent ones.

Both countries were given much more attention by Trump than Obama: Iran is brought up 17 times by Trump versus 11 by Obama, while North Korea is discussed on 16 occasions as opposed to only 3 in Obama's 2015 NSS.

Finally, and most importantly, the 2017 NSS construes "revisionist" states as representing the most serious menace to the leading position of the United States globally. The foremost great powers challenging the American global order are Russia and China. China is understood to be emerging as a peer competitor to the United States, "building the most capable and well-funded military in the world, after our own" (Trump, 2017). China is referred to 38 times by Trump, compared to only 15 by Obama, which indicates how the former cranked up the negative characterization of the PRC. The same phenomenon occurred with the Russian Federation, which is alluded to 25 times by Trump, an increase from 15 times in Obama's strategy document. The portrayal of the Russian "threat" is substantially distinct in the two National Security Strategies. Obama mostly confines his approach towards the country to a condemnation of alleged Russian "aggression" towards Ukraine in 2014 and cautioning European states against deepening their energy dependence on Russia (Obama, 2015). Despite the heavily mediatized allegations of Russian interference into the 2016 US presidential elections to the benefit of Trump, the 2017 NSS's negative assessment of Russia is in fact more comprehensive than the one provided by Obama three years prior. Russia is understood to be a revisionist state keen to revive its status of great power that was lost in 1991, and as a competitor possessing considerable and constantly growing offensive capabilities. Notably, the nuclear weapons wielded by the Kremlin are identified as "the most significant existential threat to the United States". Moreover, Russia is also opposed to American "values", practicing information warfare by exploiting the openness of American society with a view to undermining US democratic

institutions. The Russian threat-picture under Trump is thus extensive, ranging from regional destabilization through deployment of conventional forces, to cyber and nuclear capacity (Trump, 2017).

Another important aspect that is clarified by the 2017 NSS is the relationship of the United States towards specific regions, including Europe. Despite there being a change of focus and perception of the operational environment, the national security strategy as formulated by Trump still allows for extensive cooperation with other states. Close coordination with US allies, be they Atlantic or Pacific partners, is depicted as a desirable aim in itself. In this regard there is continuity with previous American administrations. A noteworthy trend that emerged in the 2010s, and which precedes Trump, is the so-called pivot to Asia, the shift of priority from the Atlantic to the Pacific Ocean as the geopolitically most interesting region for the United States. This is clearly spelled out in the order in which different regions of concern for the USA appear in both the 2015 and 2017 National Security Strategies: Asia and the Indo-Pacific are listed first, Europe comes second. The European allies, though clearly no longer occupying the center of the stage in US foreign policy, are nonetheless underscored as an important source of US security and a useful instrument for the White House in furthering its objectives of global stability, which in its view can only be achieved through the prevention of the emergence of regional hegemons. Trump sees Europe as particularly vulnerable and at a crossroads, being subjected to the risk of Russian subversion, Chinese economic infiltration and Islamic terrorism emanating from the adjacent Middle East. The presence of the United States in Europe is consequently advisable, not only to support European allies, but also to use Europe as a means to facilitate American policy-making elsewhere, such as in its interventions in the Middle East.

In the 2017 NSS, Trump maintains that the "United States remains firmly committed to our European allies and partners" as well as "to Article V of the Washington Treaty", which underpins the North Atlantic Treaty Organization. However, there is nonetheless a significant departure from the Clinton, Bush and Obama presidencies, in that Trump is not content with leading the alliance. References to NATO and allies in general come with a clearly stated expectation that partners "shoulder a fair share of the burden of responsibility", a message that is repeated throughout the document. Trump thus stresses the notion of reciprocity as a sine qua non for continued cooperation. As regards NATO, the president incites other member states to become more accountable to the organization and take on more responsibility, with an explicit request that European members boost their military expenditures to reach a benchmark of 2% by 2024 (Trump, 2017).

Evolution of Donald Trump's policy towards NATO

Over the course of the four years of Trump's first mandate, there were considerable fluctuations in the manner the President approached the question of NATO, though the demand that other member states augment their defense spending was a constant throughout the period. The attitude exhibited by Trump towards the alliance varied strongly from considering the organization pointless and outdated, to vigorously praising its work and significance to the United States.

In the months leading up to his election, Trump repeatedly called NATO "obsolete", claiming that the other allies were "ripping off" the USA by not paying enough for defense (McCaskill, 2017). A major reason for calling NATO obsolete was its limited involvement in counterterrorism, which was an important topic for Trump in the early stages of his presidency,

with a particular focus on the civil war in Syria. Trump's first interaction with a leader from a foreign country occurred on January 27, 2017, a week after his inauguration. The British Prime Minister, Theresa May, was received in the White House for a bilateral meeting, in which defense and the North Atlantic Treaty Organization were discussed, among other topics. Following the meeting, the two heads of government held a joint press conference, which May opened by reading out a prepared statement, with Trump subsequently doing the same. The event proved ominous, as only May opted to make explicit mentions of NATO during the conference, stating that "we are united in our recognition of NATO as the bulwark of our collective defense", before adding that they had "reaffirmed [their] unshakeable commitment to this alliance - Mr. President, I think you confirmed that you are 100 percent behind NATO" (Holland & Piper, 2017). There was therefore from the onset considerable ambiguity among allied leaders on the level of commitment that would be demonstrated by the new Republican administration, though these doubts somewhat dissipated after statements made by the White House in February. In a phone call with NATO Secretary General Jens Stoltenberg on February 5, followed by a press briefing two days later, the President stated his full devotion to the alliance, but also raised the issue of unequal distribution of defense spending among members (The White House, 2017a; The White House, 2017b). A number of similar and related declarations were made by Trump in the following months, for instance an affirmation in March 2017 that Germany was severely indebted to the USA by virtue of the security provided by American servicemen to the country. The claims were refuted by the German government and Ursula von der Leyen, the Minister of Defense (Martin, 2017), but contributed to shaping increasingly strained relations between the two sides of the Atlantic.

Donald Trump's approach to the organization would then oscillate during the year and a half leading up to the 2018 NATO summit in Brussels, a key event. He first met with Secretary General Stoltenberg in person at the White House on April 12, 2017. During that meeting, the American president disowned his own statement about the obsolescence of NATO, arguing that NATO had found new purpose in helping combat the Islamic state and terrorism more generally. Trump also declared that he had reached an agreement with Stoltenberg that the other member states must step up their military expenditure to target a 2% of GDP minimum (NATO, 2017a). The focus on counterterrorism was also manifest during a NATO summit held in Brussels in May 2025, in which NATO formally accepted to become part of an international coalition against ISIS, a decision that was mostly interpreted as a symbolic gesture of goodwill towards the US leader. Trump also used the summit as an opportunity to again voice his long-standing dissatisfaction with defense budgets to other leaders (Boffey & Rankin, 2017). Countries that fulfilled the expectation of 2% lower limit on defense spending were on occasion praised by Trump, such as his commendation of Poland during a state visit to the country in July that year (The White House, 2017c).

Some international security-related policies pursued by the Trump administration during the first two years of his mandate were met with criticism from European NATO countries, and this could be said to have further shook the foundations of the transatlantic partnership. Most notably, the United States opted to resume investments and research in the field of cruise missile technology with the signing of the National Defense Authorization Act on December 12, 2017. This violated provisions in the 1988 Intermediate-Range Nuclear Forces Treaty between the USA and USSR (subsequently upheld by Russia), considered a cornerstone of Euro-Atlantic security, and prompted the North Atlantic Council to issue a statement

exhorting the United States to comply with the INF Treaty (NATO, 2017b). The USA would, however, eventually withdraw entirely from the agreement in 2019, with support from allies (NATO, 2019a). Another contentious moment arose with the announced withdrawal by Trump from the so-called Iran nuclear deal in May 2018. The framework for the agreement had been jointly elaborated by the United States under Obama with three European partners - France, the UK and Germany, and the de facto annulment by Trump was poorly received (European Commission, 2018).

Transatlantic relations had thus soured noticeably by mid-2018, at which point they can be said to have reached a new low. In meetings with Stoltenberg and other member states, relations appeared tense, in particular with Canada and France. Trump reiterated his demands for higher defense expenditure by the other members, and also hinted at the possibility of returning Russia to the G7, which was met with protests by the European members of the grouping (The White House, 2018; Liptak, 2018). Tensions finally escalated during a common breakfast organized on July 11 during the first day of the 2018 NATO summit in Brussels. In a highly mediatized confrontation, Trump harshly rebuked Secretary General for the lack of funding by European member states to the organization (U.S. Embassy in Estonia, 2021), pointing out that only four members beside the United States (Estonia, Greece, Poland and the UK) met the objective of 2% of GDP. He further openly speculated that the target rate of spending should be doubled to 4%, and criticized Germany in particular for its close cooperation with the Russian fossil fuel industry while only devoting 1.2% of its GDP to its armed forces (MacAskill & Crerar, 2018).

For the remaining part of Trump's first presidential mandate, the approach taken towards the transatlantic alliance softened up, in part due to a number of European states committing themselves to increased spending. By

2020, 9 member states were satisfying the target 2% of GDP rate (NATO Public Diplomacy Division, 2024a). The Secretary General had played an important role in persuading other members to ramp up investments into military infrastructure. A meeting between Trump and Stoltenberg was held on April 2, 2019 in the White House, and unfolded in a good atmosphere. The US leader congratulated the Secretary General, whose mandate had recently been extended for another five years, and commended him for his support in helping to instigate the European members to follow up on collective burden sharing. Stoltenberg, for his part, lauded Trump for his "strong leadership" (The White House, 2019). Stoltenberg would go on to repeat his appraisal of Trump in a second meeting held in April that year (NATO, 2019b), while Trump affirmed in December at the 2019 summit that "NATO is stronger than it's ever been" (Vazquez, 2019). Notwithstanding a moderation of official rhetoric, repeated demands for budget increases and expressed dissatisfaction with perceived free riders among the alliance never abated.

Trump's last year in the White House was generally uneventful as relates to questions of foreign policy and international security. There were generally few summits or meetings between heads of state and government due to the COVID-19 pandemic. Little attention was given by world leaders to other topics, including the transatlantic partnership and security issues. During a virtual NATO summit between the countries' Ministers of Foreign Affairs held in December 2020, the outgoing Trump administration, represented by Secretary of State Mike Pompeo, reiterated the United States' faithfulness to the organization (Bureau of European and Eurasian Affairs, n.d.).

Evolution of US-French relations under Donald Trump

US-French relations also saw some variation over the period, albeit less so than was the case with NATO as a whole. This can partially be attributed to relatively high defense contributions made by France, close to the 2% target rate (World Bank, 2025), as well as a lack of opposition from the French government to the demands made by Trump. Emmanuel Macron appeared to welcome a certain decoupling between the United States and Europe, favoring the development and consolidation of purely European defense initiatives instead. In addition, the personal relationship between Macron and Trump was a rather positive one. Disagreements, however, emerged over the handling of the civil war in Syria and associated fight against international terrorism.

The first direct interaction between Trump and then president-elect Macron occurred on May 8, 2017 through a phone call, in which the leaders agreed to arrange a meeting on the sidelines of the upcoming NATO later that month (Johnson, 2017). During that meeting, the two men engaged in a series of long and uncomfortable handshakes, with Macron refusing to let go of Trump's hand on two occasions. Still, they got off to a good start in their relationship, with the two presidents congratulating each other on their recent electoral victories (Boffey & Rankin, 2017). Their alleged friendship was frequently dubbed a 'bromance' by the media (Bell & Masters, 2018), but encountered some hurdles mid-way through the period.

Upon entering office, Trump had withdrawn the United States from the 2015 Paris Agreement, and an important topic for the newly elected French president would be to convince him to reconsider addressing climate change. Macron brought up the issue on several occasions, including Trump's state visit to France on July 13-14, 2017, during which he attended the Bastille Day military parade, and during his own state visit to the USA in April the

following year (Chrisafis, 2017; Davis, 2018). Macron was unsuccessful in his attempts, but fared better in discussions on how to manage the repercussions of the Syrian conflict. Cooperation between the USA, the UK and France on Syria tightened in 2017-2018, and Trump's decision to intervene directly against the Assad regime through missile strikes was welcomed by France, in particular as a response to the alleged use of chemical weapons by the Syrian leader (CBS News, 2018). In other words, the common interest in pursuing counterterrorist operations, an important aspiration for Trump in his early political career, allowed a certain rapprochement between the United States and France, even as transatlantic relations suffered. Over time, however, the achievements of the shared operations would be undermined by Trump's unilateralist and isolationist instincts. Thus, the abrupt decision by Trump to pull out American ground troops, which numbered around two thousand, from Northeast Syria in October 2019 confounded the French allies, who had fought with the United States (Borger & Chulov, 2019; Smith, 2019). The French government was specifically concerned with the power vacuum left by the USA in Northern Syria, which paved the way for a Turkish invasion of the region. Macron subjected Trump to severe criticism, going as far as stating that the North Atlantic Alliance was in a state of "brain death" in an interview given to The Economist (The Economist, 2019), an assertion that shocked other member states. At the 2019 NATO summit in London, Trump, along with Secretary General Stoltenberg, sharply criticized Macron for his wording, deeming it "insulting" and maintaining that the alliance "serves a great purpose" (NATO, 2019c). A bilateral meeting was held between Trump and Macron at the summit, and was marked by tensions and disagreements over several issues, in particular over the civil war in Syria. It was noted that the once cordial relationship between the two heads of state had perceptibly deteriorated since the early days of 2017, when they attained office (Vazquez & Malloy, 2019). The United States would later partially backtrack the

decision to withdraw from Syria, transferring its troops to the eastern parts of the country to prevent seizure of valuable petroleum sources by the Islamic State (Al Jazeera, 2019).

Cooperation in the sphere of counterterrorism also occurred in the Sahel, though the conflicts in West Africa were arguably of far lesser importance to the United States than those in Syria. The Sahel, a geopolitical region that includes the five former French colonies of Chad, Niger, Burkina Faso, Mali and Mauritania (collectively referred to as the G5 Sahel), has been one of the most important foreign policy dimensions for France, which has sought to retain its influence in West Africa after decolonization. The region has been transformed since the Arab Spring by a series of insurrections conducted by Islamist terrorist movements, as well as military coups in the 2020s that have deposed several of the leaders that until then had cooperated with Western military forces for the maintenance of peace and stability. France notably conducted Operation Barkhane in the Sahel between 2014 and 2022 and in that respect wielded a significant military presence of over 5000 troops in the region. French and US forces in the Sahel for many years had a shared objective of preventing the spread of radical Islamist ideology from the Sahel to adjacent parts of Africa and beyond (France 24, 2021a; Yochai, 2025).

There was an asymmetry in involvement in the Sahel by the United States and France, with the latter country continuously expressing an interest in having US soldiers assist its counterterrorist operation to a greater extent. Notwithstanding the generally negative attitude to multilateral approaches exhibited by the Trump administration, the Sahel region was one of the areas where the US collaborated most efficiently with its transatlantic partners, foremost of which was France. The American effort did, however, not reach beyond a military contribution of annual 45 million dollars, and France carried

the main responsibility of propping up the West-supported regimes in the G5 Sahel. The American approach to the region has consequently been characterized as one of "indifference" (Lebovich, 2021), largely leaving France to manage the security situation in Africa as it saw fit.

Another significant development worthy of attention is the so-called 'pivot to Asia', a major turn in US foreign policy. While announced under Obama, the refocus to the 'Indo-Pacific' region intensified significantly during Donald Trump's first mandate (Manning, 2018), which impacted the White House's approach to NATO as well as appears to have influenced France's own approach to the area. It is remarkable that NATO, a regional alliance by definition constrained to the North Atlantic and adjacent countries, has come to consider the rise of the PRC as a major topic on its security agenda. NATO began to seriously consider China at the 2019 summit in London, with subsequent summits devoting increasingly more attention to the Asian country. This trajectory, manifestly ushered in by shifts in American strategic thinking, has been met with a lukewarm reception by the European members of the alliance, who are anxious not to compromise the trade and supply chains linking the EU and China in a relation of mutual dependence (Simón, 2023). Exceptions, however, include the UK and France, the two EU countries that possess territories in Asia, a legacy of their colonial period. France, in particular, appears more concerned than the average European state by the rise of China, and has readily adopted the new geopolitical concept of the 'Indo-Pacific' promoted by the United States (Manning, 2018). French territories there comprise the islands of La Réunion, Mayotte and the French Southern and Antarctic Lands in the Indian Ocean, as well as French Polynesia, Wallis and Futuna, and New Caledonia in the Pacific Ocean. The total population for the overseas possessions is slightly less than 2 million inhabitants, but they represent around 90% of France's exclusive economic

zone (Nicolas, 2019; Shvili, 2021), indicating why the region is understood to be important to the country.

During his first and second mandates, Macron paid several official visits to the overseas territories, including a visit to Mayotte and La Réunion in 2019, to French Polynesia in 2021 and to New Caledonia in 2018 in 2023 (Élysée, 2021a; Fontemaggi, 2023; Razafinarivo, 2025). The frequency of visits more or less concur with those of his predecessors, and by themselves do not demonstrate a particular increase in metropolitan interest for the region. However, while previous trips were mostly concerned with postcolonial issues and independence movements, Macron has included a geostrategic element to justify his appearances. For instance, during his stay in New Caledonia in 2018, Macron warned that "China is building its hegemony" in the Indo-Pacific (Tromeur, 2023).

France published its first Indo-Pacific strategy in 2018, a policy document outlining French priorities and ambitions for the region, and has updated it several times since then (Groupe d'études géopolitiques, 2025). The French strategy unambiguously identifies the rise of China as a source of destabilization in the region, and notes the increasingly competitive relationship between China and the USA, as the latter country has revalued its presence in Asia. Among other initiatives, France stresses the need to elaborate security partnerships with other countries present in the region, and singles out Australia, India, Japan and the United States as its closest partners, with which France should strive to pursue a "deepening of interoperability" of the respective countries' militaries (Ministry for Europe and Foreign Affairs, 2021). It is significant that these four Indo-Pacific states otherwise form a US-led loose grouping known as the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue, or 'Quad', broadly understood to be a quasi-coalition with an aim to contain China (Rajagopalan, 2021). In September 2020, France, along with India and

Australia, instituted a new regular forum for discussing issues pertaining to the region, named the Trilateral Dialogue, with one of the stated aims being to ensure "maritime safety and security" by enhancing the "interoperability of the navies" (Ministry for Europe and Foreign Affairs, 2021). In parallel with the development of an Indo-Pacific strategy, France arranged or participated in a series of military exercises in the region. These included naval exercise La Pérouse in the Gulf of Bengal in 2019, together with the US, Japanese and Australian navies (Naval Technology, 2019), and the Croix du Sud exercises in New Caledonia, which involves multiple countries participating (Ministry for Europe and Foreign Affairs, 2021).

Further developments in US-French relations in the security sphere were mostly cut off by 2020, due to the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic.

2.2 Presidency of Joe Biden (2021-2025)

Joe Biden acceded to the presidency of the United States on January 20, 2025, after a troubled handover of power from Donald Trump. From the very onset, Biden volitionally adopted a foreign policy that sought to distinguish himself from his predecessor, largely presenting himself as an 'anti-Trump'. Where Donald Trump's presidency was personified by the slogan 'America First', Joe Biden's characterizing tagline would be 'America is back', deliberately singling out the outgoing Republican administration as an anomaly and making allusions to deep-rooted post-war traditions of American liberal openness to the world, not least to its allies. While the rhetoric and public image of Biden stood in stark contrast to that of Trump, there were in fact significant strands of continuity between the two presidential administrations, in addition to important policy divergences.

Overview of the main foreign policy directions and aspirations

As with Trump, the principal foreign policy priorities of Joe Biden are outlined in the National Security Strategy. Biden was quick to adopt an interim NSS in his first year as president so as to distance himself from the previous president, before releasing a more elaborate document in October 2022 (Tebin, 2022). For analytical purposes the frequencies of keywords in the different NSS's have been counted using tools provided by Microsoft Office (see Appendix, Table 1). The juxtaposition of the 2022 National Security Strategy with the 2017 Strategy yields some notable deviations from the Trumpian foreign policy line, but also a few significant areas of convergence.

Biden's National Security Strategy conceptualizes the world as being at an "inflection point", that is, undergoing rapid and drastic changes that the United States ought to address and keep up with. The operational environment is altogether rendered as less hostile than in Trump's NSS, with the use of words like "threat" and "threaten" toned down from 110 to 69 mentions. Notwithstanding such nuances, the perception that international affairs have become more contentious and confrontational, already present in the 2017 NSS, is manifestly reproduced in the 2022 iteration of the document. In fact, Joe Biden ups the ante, with "competition" and words of the same root repeated 102 times, compared to 57 times under Trump and only 10 times in Obama's last NSS from 2015 (Biden, 2022; Trump, 2017). Paradoxically, considering that Biden served eight years as vice president under Obama, Biden shares more in common with Trump in his understanding of the world as deeply divided and on the verge of major conflict.

The security challenges defined by Biden do, however, differ somewhat from those of Trump. In particular, there is a reorientation of attention from

non-state actors to state actors as sources of destabilization and danger. Terrorism does not occupy nearly the same space in Biden's threat evaluation, with all keywords appearing less frequently: "terrorism" and "terrorist" (37 instances in NSS 2022 versus 70 instances in NSS 2017), Al-Qaeda (3 versus 9 instances) and ISIS/Islamic State (2 versus 12 instances). In parallel with a diminished focus on Islamic terrorist attacks, less attention is also granted to the Middle East in general. For example, "Syria" is mentioned only 3 times, compared to 6 in Trump's Strategy. This approach would, however, be modified following the October 7, 2023 attack of Hamas in Israel, which renewed American attentiveness to the region. It is also notable how rogue states, of which the foremost are Iran and North Korea, are given a more superficial treatment. Reference is made to Iran and North Korea only 7 and 3 times, respectively, compared to 17 and 16 in Trump's NSS (Biden, 2022; Trump, 2017).

Where Joe Biden does concur with Donald Trump, however, is in the identification of "revisionist" states as the principal challenge to US security. Like Trump, Biden understands China and Russia to be United States' chief competitors on the global arena. China is described as the only country in the world possessing "both the intent to reshape the international order and, increasingly, the economic, diplomatic, military and technological power to do it" (Biden, 2022). China is mentioned 57 times in Biden's Strategy, an increase from Trump's 38 mentions (Biden, 2022; Trump, 2017). There is thus an important continuity between the Trump and Biden administrations in their approach towards the PRC, and in effect the latter did not scale down the trade war initiated by his predecessor (Tankersley, 2024). An unprecedented amount of attention is devoted to Russia, cited 71 times - far more often than any other country, and a considerable increase from Trump's 25 mentions. This should be seen in context with the escalation of the Russo-Ukrainian

conflict earlier in 2022 following the announcement of Russia's Special Military Operation, as a hike in interest in Ukraine (only one single mention made by Trump in the whole 2017 NSS, but 33 mentions in Biden's NSS) parallels the abovementioned pattern for Russia (Biden, 2022, Trump, 2017). While the rise of the People's Republic of China is interpreted as a long-term challenge to the US-led world order, Russia is presented more alarmingly as an "immediate threat". The treatment given to China and Russia in Biden's National Security Strategy has in common that both are draped in a negative characterization centering on their state system of "authoritarian governance". Biden thus draws a sharp distinction between the allegedly progressive American vision for the world and the "illiberal" agenda of its two main rivals. It is noteworthy how the whole document is suffused with classical liberal rhetoric and commonplace formulations, with the terms "democracy" and "democratic" being repeated 99 times throughout (Biden, 2022).

Finally, allusions to the 'pivot to Asia' announced by Obama, and which were visibly present during Trump's presidency, are also to be found in Biden's conception of national security. The Indo-Pacific is again listed first among the regions in the "Our strategy by region" section of the 2022 NSS, and headlined as "Promote a Free and Open Indo-Pacific", immediately followed by Europe under the heading "Deepen Our Alliance with Europe". While the former region is clearly stated to be "the epicenter of 21st century geopolitics" and no "region will be of more significance to the world", there de facto appears to be a refocusing back towards the European continent. It is telling that references made to "Europe" and "Europeans" are made over three times more frequently than to "Asia" and "Asians" (Biden, 2022). This can once more be interpreted as a consequence of the crisis in Ukraine, which resumed during Biden's mandate.

Evolution of Joe Biden's policy towards NATO

The transatlantic partnership was a central pillar of Joe Biden's defense and foreign policy, and underwent a renewal over the course of his presidential period. The North Atlantic Treaty Organization is referred to 19 times throughout the 2022 NSS, an increase from the 6 mentions in the 2017 NSS. Biden's appraisal of NATO centers on two dimensions: its role in propping up the United States in the conflict that opposes it to Russia since 2022, and its role in preserving security and stability on the European continent, which in turn relies on deterrence. The US President highlighted the reinforcement of the Eastern European flank under way, as well as the enlargement of the alliance in Northern Europe, adding Finland and Sweden to its list of members. The vow to upholding Article 5 of the North Atlantic Treaty is restated more forcefully than in previous National Security Strategies, with formulations such as "the United States will defend every inch of NATO territory" and "America remains unequivocally committed" to the stipulations "enshrined in NATO's Article 5". The document also assesses the organization to be "stronger and more united than it has ever been". Simultaneously, the notion of burden sharing, while not underscored to the same extent, carries over from Trump's approach to the alliance. Thus, in Biden's view, the United States still expects its transatlantic partners, and the European ones in particular, "to continue assuming greater responsibility by increasing their spending, capabilities and contributions" (Biden, 2022).

The Biden administration's approach towards NATO can be divided into two phases: one preceding the start of the Special Military Operation on February 24, 2022 and spanning roughly one year, and another running parallel to the evolution of the SMO. The initial period was mostly concentrated on reaffirming American dedication to the alliance, and sought to mitigate the perceived damage that the Trump administration had caused.

This mostly took the form of renewed assurances and trust-building. Within one week of taking office, Biden had a phone call with NATO Secretary General Jens Stoltenberg, whose declared aim was to reconstruct the partnership. Biden's election was deemed "the start of a new chapter for our transatlantic Alliance", and both leaders underscored the "need to maintain the momentum for increased defence spending" (NATO, 2021), that is, the insistence on burden sharing inherited from the days of Trump was retained. The main event of that first period was the 2021 summit in Brussels, during which the NATO 2030 agenda was adopted. The agenda is devised as a program setting goals for the modernization of the organization, while broadening its scope to also include cybersecurity and climate security (NATO, 2022). While Russia is designated as the principal obstacle to stability in the Euro-Atlantic region, more recent geopolitical considerations originating in the United States were clearly influential on the making of the agenda. Once more, it is notable that the rise of China is presented as a cause of concern for the alliance, despite this being beyond the remit of the alliance. This strand of thought first appeared during the 2019 London summit, but was solidified with the 2030 agenda (Simón, 2023). The intertwining of the Euro-Atlantic and Indo-Pacific regions, a foreign policy trajectory that is mainly pushed by the United States, has direct implications for France in particular, as the latter country possesses several territories in both the Indian and Pacific Oceans.

During the second phase, after the onset of the Special Military Operation in Ukraine, the role of the United States in NATO would emerge as a coordinator in the efforts to prop up the Ukrainian side of the conflict. Most of the endeavors undertaken by Biden vis-a-vis NATO for the remaining three years of his presidency can be seen as a response to the intensification of the fighting in Ukraine. This is also apparent from the frequency of NATO

summits, with six top-level plenum meetings organized over the course of his mandate. Thus, with the exception of George W. Bush, more NATO summits were held under Biden than any other US president in history, despite Biden serving only one term as president (NATO, 2024b). The response by the Biden administration was multipronged, and included expanding the organization to new members Finland and Sweden, a decision which was approved by the US Congress and ratified presidentially in August 2022 (Macias, 2022), reinforcing the eastern member states, for instance by transferring three thousand combat troops from North Carolina to Poland (Burns, 2022), implementing economic sanctions against Russia, and providing the Armed Forces of Ukraine with equipment and intelligence, all while repeating the claim that NATO remained open to a potential Ukrainian membership at an unspecified time in the future (Trelsman, 2024).

Data published by NATO on an annual basis indicate that the policies of Trump and Biden towards the alliance, though delivered in starkly contrasting language, appear to have had a real impact on the defense expenditures of the other member states. The most revealing statistic is the number of NATO member states meeting the target defense spending rate of 2% of GDP. It increased from 4 members in 2017, when Trump took office, to 9 members when he left office. For Biden, the equivalent numbers are 6 members in 2021, up to 23 members in an estimation for 2024. Thus, there is an overall increase from 4 to 23 member states fulfilling the minimum requirements. There was also an upward trend in real changes for non-US NATO expenditure, with each consecutive year between 2017 and 2024 witnessing an increase in collective defense spending, with 2017 (5.9%), 2023 (9.3%) and 2024 (17.9%) seeing the largest increases over the previous year. Measured in constant 2015 prices, the total amount spent on defense for said members augmented considerably, from 277 billion dollars to 430 billion

dollars. However, it could be argued that the escalation of the conflict in Ukraine had the most impact on European countries' willingness to invest in their militaries, considering that the largest spikes across all statistics occurred in 2023 and 2024. Measured in fixed 2015 prices, France experienced a slight increase in defense spending between 2017 and 2021 (from 1.78% of GDP to 1.91%), as well as from 2017 to 2024 (1.78% to 2.06%). Defense spending per capita also saw an upsurge, from 668 dollars in 2017 to 720 dollars in 2021, and 801 dollars in an estimate for 2024 (NATO Public Diplomacy Division, 2024a).

Evolution of US-French relations under Joe Biden

Franco-American relations evolved according to a different pattern during the four years of Joe Biden's administration than during the four preceding years, when Trump was in the White House. While Trump's period had seen an initially strong start with cordial exchanges between Trump and Macron, then followed by a progressive cooling down of the amicable discourse, the period under Biden displayed an almost inverted tendency, as his administration experienced a major crisis in bilateral relations with France in his first year in office, before relations slowly improved over the remainder of the mandate. In the domain of defense, the conflict in Ukraine was clearly the most significant topic drawing the two nations together. Nevertheless, there were also developments in other areas, such as Afghanistan, the Sahel, counterterrorism, the Gaza war and the Indo-Pacific.

Emmanuel Macron was among the first foreign leaders contacted by Joe Biden upon inauguration, reflecting his status as one of the United States' foremost partners. Biden first spoke with Macron in late January 2021, which marked the first contact between the two men in their capacity as heads of

state, and referred to France as “our oldest ally”. The stated aim of the new US president was to reinforce the bilateral relationship, for which purpose the main venue was identified as the transatlantic system. The presidents also staked out a set of foreign policy priorities common to the two states, namely China, Russia, the Middle East and the Sahel (The White House, 2021a). The interaction was followed up by a second phone call with Vice President Kamala Harris on February 15, in which many of the same talking points were discussed (The White House, 2021b). Biden and Macron then met in person at Carbis Bay, the UK on June 12 at the annual G7 summit. The bilateral meeting organized at the sidelines of the multilateral conference focused mainly on healthcare and economic affairs, though the need to “modernize” NATO was also brought up, as well as security issues of prime concern to both countries, most notably China, Russia and counterterrorism in the Sahel region (U.S. Mission to France, 2021a).

The apparently harmonious bilateral relations gave way, however, to some tensions by the end of Biden’s first year in the White House, which became manifest with the chaotic withdrawal of the United States from Afghanistan in August 2021. France had cooperated closely with its US partners in the country during several administrations following the invasion in 2001, before finally pulling out its combat troops in 2014, leaving mainly civilian personnel left for civic and human rights efforts. The remaining French nationals, as well as hundreds of Afghans that had worked for the French, hastily left Afghanistan in conjunction with the American departure. France also played a central role in evacuating other EU citizens (Élysée, 2021b). The disorganized closure to the allied operation in Afghanistan, precipitated by the US decision to terminate its presence on Afghan soil, was met with criticism from the French government, though Macron reaffirmed his sympathies for the initial motives that had led the United States to

intervene in the country in 2001. In particular, Macron expressed dismay at the refusal of Joe Biden to prolong the evacuation process beyond August 31st, which would have granted other foreign stakeholders precious time to organize their own withdrawal, but simultaneously cautioned against labeling it as a "betrayal" (China Daily, 2021; Élysée, 2021b). Biden, after facing both bipartisan and international criticism, responded by rejecting the remonstrances, declaring that it was still the "right decision". Part of the motivation to end the war in Afghanistan was a desire to refocus foreign policy on China and Russia (The White House, 2021c).

A much larger rift in bilateral US-French relations would emerge the ensuing month in connection with the announcement of AUKUS on September 15. AUKUS - short for Australia, United Kingdom and United States - is a security partnership between three Anglo-Saxon countries, largely interpreted as a measure taken to contest the PRC's growing influence in the Indo-Pacific region. As part of the agreement, Australia agreed to purchase a series of eight nuclear-powered submarines from the United States in upcoming years. The direct consequence of the announcement was the cancellation of a similar deal to acquire twelve diesel-powered Attack-class submarines from France. The latter business partnership had been in the making since 2016, and was estimated to cost Australia around 65 billion US dollars, which would have benefitted the French defense industry (Vazquez, 2021a). The French Naval Group partners to the Australian deal were not notified in due time, learning about the cancellation upon the announcement of AUKUS. The news were met with shock and perplexity among the French political elite, which denounced the rupture as a betrayal (Vaissié, 2025). French Minister of Foreign Affairs Jean-Yves Le Drian went as far as calling the move a "stab in the back". Two days after the proclamation of the new partnership, France called back its ambassadors to the United States and

Australia, an unprecedented step in the more recent history of bilateral relations. (Vazquez, 2021a).

In the following week, Biden avoided making references to France when discussing AUKUS (France 24, 2021b). On September 22, Macron and Biden resumed contact in a phone call between the leaders, which produced a joint statement. Above all, the American president recognized that the negotiation process surrounding the submarines and defense cooperation more broadly would gain from more transparent communication and deliberation, and pledged to improve relations with both France and other European states in that regard. Biden and Macron also used the occasion to discuss common security interests of the USA and France, in particular the Indo-Pacific and the Sahel. In regards to the latter region, Biden promised to strengthen assistance to French counterterrorist action. The French president in return agreed to return his ambassador to Washington D.C. (U.S. Mission to France, 2021b), which occurred a week later, on September 29 (The Straits Times, 2021). On October 5, US Secretary of State Anthony Blinken spoke in Paris with Macron and Le Drian at the sidelines of an OECD event. The diplomatic crisis had wider implications than just US-French ties, as the Biden administration was engaged in a process of rebuilding trust between the two sides of the Atlantic after Trump's presidency. Blinken, who had spent part of his childhood in Paris and could draw on close familial bonds to the country, was credited with having played a crucial role in easing tensions between the United States and France during the submarine crisis (Crowley, 2021; Erlanger & Jakes, 2021). More progress in improving relations was made at the G20 summit in Rome, during which Biden and Macron arranged a bilateral meeting at the French embassy. The former admitted to having managed the submarine affair inelegantly, characterizing it as "clumsy" and describing France as "an extremely valued partner". Macron expressed a

desire to move beyond the crisis. Among the concessions made by the United States were a reiterated promise to help France in its operations in the Sahel, as well as statements that a consolidated European defence system, a long-term ambition for Macron, could serve as "complementary" to already existing NATO (Vazquez, 2021b). Finally, Vice President Kamala Harris was received in Paris on November 9 as part of an official state visit. After the meeting, bilateral relations became more or less normalized (Rogers, 2021)

Notwithstanding the submarine crisis, coordination between the United States and France in managing the conflict in Ukraine did not always appear smooth. This was manifest in the interactions of the two leaders with Russian President Vladimir Putin, both before and after the escalation of the conflict in February 2022. Biden meet Putin in Geneva in June 2021, and engaged him multiple times throughout 2021 and early 2022 over video and phone calls (Belam et al., 2021; Smith, 2021). Macron made a visit to Moscow on February 7, 2022, in another highly mediatized high-stakes meeting, and a follow-up phone call on February 20, four days before the start of the Special Military Operation (President of Russia, 2022; Élysée, 2022a). Biden's interactions with Putin were generally inimical, and the two leaders held separate press conferences following their in-person meeting in Switzerland (Belam et al., 2021). Macron fared somewhat better and appeared to strike a less confrontational tone; the French and Russian presidents were able to hold a joint press conference after their February meeting. Macron also expressed optimism that a solution to the Ukrainian crisis would be found by working together (President of Russia, 2022). The attempt by Macron to engage Putin directly can be seen in the light of a will to distance himself from the United States and sustain an image of France as an independent actor in international affairs, capable of arranging high-level negotiations and function as an intermediary between conflicting parties (Macron made a state visit to

Ukraine immediately after the talks with Putin) (Borger et al., 2022). Simultaneously, Macron appeared to speak on behalf of Europe as a whole when entering talks with the Russian president, showcasing his aspirations for a more united Europe in defense matters. Nonetheless, Macron was blatantly unsuccessful in reaching a meaningful agreement with his Russian counterpart, and the limits of his strategic autonomy were put on display as he scrambled to set up a meeting between Biden and Putin in the last days preceding the SMO, thus tacitly acknowledging the necessity to include the United States for any effective agreement (Élysée, 2022a). France also conferred multiple times with the United States throughout the process. For instance, the two leaders called each other on February 9 and 15, sharing their experience and evaluating both leaders' recent conversations with President Putin (The White House, 2022a; The White House, 2022b), while also going over possible countermeasures if Russia were to initiate its Special Military Operation.

After the onset of the Special Military Operation on February 24, 2022, the Biden administration opted to cut direct communication with the Russian government. France, however, pursued a different trajectory, choosing to maintain an open line of contact with Russia. This included several phone calls between Macron and Putin to discuss specifics related to the conflict, such as the peril of a nuclear accident linked to fighting near the Zaporizhzhia power plant, and the repercussions on global food security (Élysée, 2022b). There were also other nuances in the approach taken by France to the conflict, which sometimes contrasted with the line adopted by the United States. The most important of these was the controversial statement made by Macron in February 2024 about the possibility of sending French and other European troops to Ukraine. The affirmation came after a top-level meeting of European leaders in Paris, gathered to exchange views on further support for Ukraine.

Macron indicated that sending ground troops to Ukraine was one of the options discussed among the leaders, and while no consensus had been attained on the question, he refused to exclude the possibility. The assertion was negatively received by several other European NATO member states, who discarded the idea. The approach violated a taboo that had thus far restrained NATO from engaging with the prospect of a direct intervention into Ukraine. That was also the case with the United States, as Joe Biden had been clear that no American soldiers would ever be dispatched to fight against Russia (Bryant et al., 2024), an outlook that has remained unchanged so far in the conflict. Notwithstanding the provoked controversy, Macron reiterated his statements about possible French troops in Ukraine on several occasions over the spring of 2024, now visibly identifying the outcome of the Russo-Ukrainian conflict with the security of Europe as a whole (France 24, 2024b). The French leader gradually began to use the conflict as a means to promote his vision for a common European defense system, increasingly understood to be separate from the American component in the transatlantic partnership. A year before Donald Trump's reelection, Macron maintained that the Ukrainian conflict was primarily a "European war", and that Europe as such should not depend on "the American voter" for its defense (Breeden & Méheut, 2024).

Over the course of 2021, Macron continued to meet with Biden at regular intervals, leading up to a state visit to the United States in December 2022. In the joint statement released after the bilateral meeting, security issues featured prominently. NATO was hailed as a pillar of their security relationship, while recognition was also granted to the need for a strengthened European defense that can be "complementary to and interoperable with NATO". The two leaders pledged to cooperate more closely on defense, in particular to consult with each other on the development of cyber, intelligence

and other high-tech capabilities. They commented that some progress had already been made through the establishment of a US-French Defense Trade Security Dialogue earlier that year. Further remarks were made on four key areas of common interest: Ukraine, the Indo-Pacific, Africa and the Middle East. On the topic of Ukraine, Biden and Macron declared their unwavering support for the country "for as long as it takes", and agreed to shortly provide Kiev with more air defense systems (U.S. Embassy Beirut, 2022). Biden made only one state visit to France, towards the end of his presidential mandate. His visit between June 5 and 9, 2024 was timed to coincide with the eighty year anniversary of D-Day. The joint statement that was released after the visit mostly repeated the same talking points from Macron's state visit two years prior, including as regards the conflict in Ukraine. The statement lauded " the density and breadth of the U.S.-French defense relationship". The regional scope was, however, wider, and included specifics on security issues in Moldova, the Western Balkans, and South Caucasus, a section on the Western hemisphere, as well as details on the two countries' stance on the Gaza War, which had erupted in between the two meetings (The American Presidency Project, 2024).

In official discourse, the United States and France favor a two-state solution to the protracted Israeli-Palestinian conflict. Both countries are nonetheless usually perceived to be de facto Israeli allies, including in the Gaza War that began on October 7, 2023 (McGreal, 2023). The conflict, initially concentrated in the Gaza Strip and adjacent areas between Israel and Egypt, produced a wider conflagration in the Middle Eastern region that has included skirmishes along the Lebanese border, exchanges of missiles between Israel and Iran, and attacks on international shipping in the Red Sea by the Yemeni-based Houthis. While Israel so far has benefited from unwavering support by the USA throughout the conflict, the French approach

has been somewhat more tempered. The distance between US and French attitudes to the conflict widened by the end of 2024 due to differing views on a potential ceasefire in Gaza and the invasion of Lebanon by Israel in October. The countries made contrasting comments on Israel's assassination of Hezbollah leader Hassan Nasrallah in September 2024, with France expressing concern for possible destabilization of the Israeli-Lebanese border area, while the US voiced approval. Moreover, France was highly critical of the following ground invasion of Lebanon by the IDF, whereas the United States were broadly understood to have offered the latter a green light for escalating the fighting with Hezbollah along the Blue Line and beyond. Thus, France has visibly sought to balance the conflicting foreign policy aims of safeguarding Lebanon's sovereignty and territorial integrity, and supporting Israeli defense. In a move that may have been motivated by the significant French diaspora living in the Lebanon, France was the first state to send a top-level official to Beirut after Israel's aerial strikes against the country (Medini, 2024). Later in October, Macron urged the international community to cease weapons shipments to Israel, and seemed to criticize the United States for their considerable military aid packages to the country, deemed hypocritical in combination with American calls for a ceasefire: "those who provide [weapons] cannot every day call for a cease-fire alongside us and continue to supply them" (Francis et al., 2024).

France's approach has been more coherent with the American one as regards the role of Iran in the conflict. The two countries, which possess nuclear weapons in accordance with the Non-Proliferation Treaty, have a vested interest in preventing Iran from developing its own nuclear arsenal. Achieving complete Iranian compliance with the International Atomic Energy Agency is a stated long-time goal of both the United States and France. The two allies have also decried the Iranian funding of various groupings in the

Middle East, which they perceive as destabilizing to the region (The American Presidency Project, 2024). The USA and France jointly assisted Israel during the 2024 clash with Iran, most notably helping shield the former country from missile attacks by the latter (Breeden & Specia, 2024).

France has been clear in its support for the upholding of shipping lanes in international waters, and with that objective in mind has committed one frigate to Operation Prosperity Guardian in the Red Sea, a US-led operation aimed at containing the Houthis (Bureau of Political-Military Affairs, 2025). However, France quickly appeared to withdraw support for the American coalition, and it was reported that it would no longer be part of the operation in late 2023 (Maritime News, 2023). Instead, the French navy would operate on its own and prioritize the escort of French commercial vessels. Nevertheless, cooperation eventually continued in 2024, though the French contribution to Prosperity Guardian operated independently from US command. The French Ministry of Armed Forces welcomed the American initiative for patrolling the Red Sea in an official communiqué, but insisted that France would retain national control over its ships so as to "guarantee our freedom of action", also stating that there would be "no subordination" to the US (Irish & Saul, 2024; Lagneau, 2023).

US-French military cooperation also continued in Africa. When entering office, Joe Biden inherited from Trump a small US presence in the Sahel consisting of a few hundred ground troops, though these were understood to be crucial for the maintenance of overall stability in West Africa. The regional foothold of the United States deteriorated rapidly over the course of the Biden administration, in a development largely mirroring that of France. The military presence of both countries was dramatically diminished as a result of new military governments in the Sahel countries renouncing their cooperation agreements with Western states (France 24,

2024a). France and the United States initially declared to continue their common campaign against terrorism in the Sahel, insisting in late 2022 that counterterrorism and preventing the spread of disinformation endured as "joint priorities" in their Africa policy (U.S. Embassy Beirut, 2022). However, by 2024, the geopolitical reality of the region, with a drastically reduced Western presence and limited capacity to act on the ground, appeared to have caught up with the leaders, and Biden and Macron modified their policies to an approach focusing on humanitarian aspects, effectively substituting diplomacy for the military as the principal policy instrument in the Sahel (The American Presidency Project, 2024). From an American perspective, the operations in the Sahel appeared peripheral to the more consequential conflicts unfolding in the Middle East, and the Biden administration's capacity to respond to the security deterioration in West Africa was constrained by involvement in other conflicts, most notably the Special Military Operation in Ukraine. France's simultaneous failure to defend its position in the region, despite it being a major foreign policy priority, appears to be the result of the combined impact of overextended capacity as well as rising anti-French sentiment in the wider region. All while proving unable to adequately address their weakened position in the Sahel, it is noteworthy that both countries perceive their replacement with Russian mercenaries, which they qualify as "proxies", as a source of concern (The American Presidency Project, 2024).

The Indo-Pacific dimension of the United States and France's security partnership also continued to develop over the course of Joe Biden's presidency. In April 2021, France invited the four members of the Quad to participate in its La Pérouse naval exercise, marking the first time France executed a training program with all four Quad members simultaneously (Rajagopalan, 2021). Nonetheless, the tensions caused by the announcement

of AUKUS put a dent in efforts to synchronize military cooperation in the Indian and Pacific Oceans. Foreign Affairs minister Le Drian acknowledged that the American interference with the French-Australian submarine deal came at a particularly inopportune moment, as both countries were "facing unprecedented challenges in the Indo-Pacific" (Vazquez, 2021a), an indirect reference to increased Chinese blue-water maritime capabilities. US Secretary of State Anthony Blinken smoothed out frictions by referring to France as a "vital partner" in the Indo-Pacific, and assured that the USA desired to "deepen our trans-Atlantic cooperation in the Indo-Pacific" (Vazquez, 2021a), a remarkable statement that stretches the scope of the transatlantic alliance far beyond its conventional framework centered on Europe.

Still, the approach taken by France to the Indo-Pacific is distinct from that of the United States. Even as France has continued to engage in joint naval exercises with the USA, such as in the SAMASAMA exercise in the Philippine Sea in 2023 and the Valiant Shield exercise in the South China Sea in 2024 (France in the Philippines and in Micronesia, 2024; Naval News, 2024), France did not fully align with the American vision of bipolar great power competition with China in the region. While the government in Paris has made note of the changed strategic environment produced by the PRC's more assertive posturing, it has avoided siding unequivocally with Washington, D.C. Instead, France insisted on the multilateral principles and the rules-based order that underpin international security, and referred repeatedly to the United Nations Convention on the Laws of the Sea (UNCLOS) as the appropriate guideline for resolution of territorial conflicts in the Pacific, most notably in the South China Sea. France's approach has been less bellicose and confrontational than the American, though it has insisted on free naval passage in the South China Sea and challenged China's territorial claims there, in accordance with UNCLOS (Groupe d'études géopolitiques,

2025). Moreover, despite regularly participating in joint naval exercises with the countries of the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue, France seems to lack enthusiasm for expanded cooperation and has resisted participation in 'Quad Plus' formats, privileging its bilateral relations instead (Pajon, 2021). The country has also increasingly taken on a role of representation for the European Union in the Indo-Pacific during Emmanuel Macron's presidency, frequently identifying its foreign policy goals in the region with broader European ones, and aiming for the French overseas territories to "become footholds for EU actions in the region" (Ministry for Europe and Foreign Affairs, 2021). The European Union launched its own Indo-Pacific Strategy in September 2021, a decision that France had actively encouraged, seeing greater EU involvement in the Indo-Pacific as an extension of its own strategy for the region (Groupe d'études géopolitiques, 2025).

3. Analysis of the Impact of US Policy on French Defense Policy

3.1 Defense Dilemma: US Pressures vs. French Strategic Culture

French strategic culture is a complex one, much so due to the competing visions that have long divided its political elite as well as public opinion. Whereas most other European members of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization opted to bandwagon with the United States during the Cold War and in the post-1991 era, tacitly accepting the preeminence of the latter within the alliance, France early on struck out on a different path that was conducive to greater strategic ambiguity. At the heart of the French dilemma are two contradictory considerations of what role it should occupy in its postcolonial period. On the one hand, France has been a heavyweight member of NATO and has cultivated close political, economic and diplomatic ties with the United States since long before the emergence of the alliance. This would make the country a major participant in the transatlantic partnership. On the other hand, there has been a strong political undercurrent in French society since the 1950s favoring greater autonomy from the United States (and other great powers). This has materialized in military relations that have been less intimate than what the otherwise close political affiliation between the two countries would suggest.

The Atlanticist vision of France

The Atlanticist tradition, favoring close-knit security cooperation with the United States, springs from the political reality of a divided post-war Europe, in which the prospect of an attack by the USSR was perceived as an existential threat. For most of the Cold War, the fault lines ran through Germany, meaning that Soviet aggression was not such a distant specter for

French policymakers - a mere few hundred kilometers separated the French Occupation Zone in Germany, as well as the French mainland itself, from the territory of the opposing bloc (Lieven, 2024). A France that was militarily weakened after the Second World War, was losing much of its geostrategic significance due to progressive loss of overseas colonies, and was unable to withstand by itself the pressures of a rising Soviet Union, was ultimately forced to turn to the United States for backup. It can also be argued that the Atlanticist faction in French politics grounds its worldview in a more foundational perception of the United States as a natural partner that shares the same democratic values and objectives.

Despite France continuously remaining a NATO member, the Atlanticist current suffered somewhat during the Cold War, especially after France acquired nuclear capabilities, which gave the opposing 'sovereigntist' movement much credibility. Centrist political parties as well as non-communist politicians of the left were initially strongly against De Gaulle's monumental decision in 1966 and wished to rejoin NATO. Over the 1970s, a shift occurred, with the left gradually converging towards the Gaullist line, which was mostly kept intact under the presidency of socialist François Mitterrand, starting in 1981. Consequently, there was a certain blurring of the previously clear-cut left-right division on the NATO question in French politics, and the Atlanticist vision has not fully prevailed on the center-left since then (Boniface, 2021). Nevertheless, after 1991, Atlanticism again gained in prominence as France began a policy of realignment with the USA. Though the rhetoric of Gaullism never disappeared from official political discourse, the transatlantic ideology had de facto entered the realm of mainstream politics and had become the centerpiece of the country's defense strategy (Schmitt, 2017). Atlanticists rejected the Gaullist considerations of sovereignty and complete independence in foreign policy decisions. In their

view, American leadership was central to the West's victory in the Cold War, which was rendered possible by the decision of most Western countries to follow the lead of the United States, often formulating policy in lockstep with Washington, D.C. From this perspective, the nonconformist aspirations of De Gaulle and most of his successors are understood to have been counterproductive to the national interests of France (Boniface, 2021).

Contemporary, post-Cold War Atlanticism still perceives the USA as a natural leader of the West, which France ought to collaborate closely with. Its proponents' strategic vision for the country has, however, undergone some changes since 1991. From their perspective, France is no longer facing an ideological menace in the form of a communist USSR, but a combined threat from a resurrected, revisionist Russia, an increasingly assertive China, and Islamic terrorism from the Middle East. Thus, to some extent, the Atlanticist movement in France can be said to have taken a civilizational, 'Occidentalist' turn, where Western civilization, embodied through ideals of democracy, individualism and liberalism, is pitted against authoritarian rivals. It also mirrors the increased influence of neo-Conservatives in the United States in the 2000s, who campaigned for a more aggressive foreign policy in the non-Western world. The presidency of Nicolas Sarkozy (2007-2012) can be seen against this background, including the decision to rejoin NATO's integrated central command in 2009 and the UN-sanctioned intervention in Libya in 2011 (Boniface, 2021). He justified his policies by arguing that France and the United States belong to the same Western family, underscoring that the two countries "share a common history and values" (Élysée, 2012). Likewise, successor François Hollande's (2012-2017) involvement in the Syrian Civil War can be understood as derived from the same Atlanticist vein. The degree of concord and strategic unity with the United States that is nurtured by French Atlanticists should nevertheless not be overemphasized.

For instance, Sarkozy adopted a rather neutral stance in the Russo-Georgian conflict of 2008 and acted as a mediator between the two states, while the USA publicly condemned Russia (Boniface, 2021). Earlier that same year, France and the United States had also disagreed on the prospect of Georgian and Ukrainian NATO membership, with France opting to oppose the US initiative to expand the alliance eastwards.

There is no clear division among parties in the French political system as regards the question of NATO and the strategic path to be followed by France. The position of parties has been known to fluctuate, and individual politicians have highly contrasting views on the issue, which can sometimes deviate from the official course adopted by the party with which they are affiliated. In general terms, centrist parties are the staunchest defenders of transatlantic cooperation in contemporary France. This includes most notably *Les Républicains* (The Republicans, LR, formerly known as UMP and RPR), one of two parties that used to dominate French politics for decades along with the competing *Parti Socialiste* (Socialist Party, PS). The Republicans were previously identified with a purely Gaullist line, but appear to have modified their approach in recent years due to increasing competition from far-right presidential candidates (the last time LR won a presidential election was in 2007). Though the decision by Sarkozy in 2009 to rejoin NATO's integrated command structure was highly controversial within the party, their official program now rejects the notion of withdrawing from it once more. Instead, it proposes to build a stronger European defense, with massive investments to boost the homegrown French and European defense industry, thus creating a strong "European pillar" within NATO. There is thus a strong Gaullist undercurrent that is still discernible in LR, but the continued importance of working with "our American allies" is nonetheless underscored. The party also suggests increasing defence spending across NATO to 3% of

GDP (Les Républicains, 2024), echoing American demands of greater burden sharing. The LR candidate for the 2022 presidential election, Valérie Pécresse, affirmed her support for NATO, all while maintaining that “alliance does not signify allegiance” (Cantié, 2022).

The Socialist Party has evolved according to a similar trend, facing comparable pressure from an emerging far-left movement. The PS candidate for the same election, Anne Hidalgo, considered the United States and France as “unwavering allies” with “a common history”, but highlighted the need to strengthen the European component of the organization. President Emmanuel Macron’s party *Renaissance* (formerly known as *La République en marche !*), while clearly also under the influence of the Gaullist tradition, has opted to promote a continued French presence in NATO, renouncing the possibility of leaving the alliance (Cantié, 2022).

Public opinion research conducted annually by NATO since 2019 indicates that the organization enjoys rather high support among the French population. The questionnaire is slightly modified from year to year, but some key aspects can be tracked over time. To the question ‘How important do you consider the relationship between North America and Europe in dealing with security challenges today?’, 73% and 72% of French respondents answered with ‘Very important’ or ‘Somewhat important’ in 2019 and 2021, respectively. The 2024 survey saw a similarly formulated question: ‘Do you think France is more safe as a result of the cooperation between North American and European NATO nations?’, to which 50% responded positively. Additionally, in the same survey 66% of the French public perceived NATO as important to the “future security” of France (NATO, 2020; NATO Public Diplomacy Division, 2022, NATO Public Diplomacy Division, 2024b). There thus appears to be significant approval of the transatlantic partnership between France and the United States. However, it

should be noted that the French data tend to be at the lower end of the range for alliance members. Despite a majority of over 70% endorsing NATO in the 2019 and 2021 surveys, these numbers were some of the lowest in the organization and considerably below the average value of 81%. In fact, only three member states (Montenegro, Slovakia and Bulgaria) registered lower support for NATO in 2021. Moreover, approximately half the French population considers that French NATO membership makes it less likely that France will experience foreign aggression (54% in 2019, 49% in 2021, 57% in 2024), highlighting that the organization is generally perceived as useful. Still, these scores are once more among the lowest in the alliance, with France displaying the fourth lowest value in 2021 after the USA, Montenegro and Slovakia. There is nonetheless an emerging trend of increasing endorsement of French membership in the organization. While only 50% of respondents in 2019 and 2021 declared that they would vote to remain in NATO if a referendum was held, this score had increased to 61% by 2024 (NATO, 2020; NATO Public Diplomacy Division, 2022; NATO Public Diplomacy Division, 2024b), a development that can be seen in light of the escalation of tensions in Ukraine since 2022 (Marcadé, 2022).

The Gaullist vision of France

Just like the Atlanticist vision, the Gaullist (or sovereigntist) tradition in French political life takes its origins in the immediate post-war years, as the French leadership began to react to the dominating position of the United States in the West and beyond. France was undergoing a process of decolonization in the 1950s and early 1960s, which the United States helped catalyze, to great dismay of the French. The 1956 Suez Crisis proved humiliating to France, as not only the Soviet Union but also the United States

actively opposed French intervention in Egypt, effectively sapping trust between the USA and France. Though France would remain safely within the Western camp throughout the whole Cold War, this incident fueled a desire to seek a more neutral position in the international system, the primary means to which was the country's own nuclear weapons program. Ultimately, under the oversight of President Charles de Gaulle, the French nuclear program was conceived as a deterrent not against the Soviet bloc, but as a universal deterrent against all other states (Schmitt, 2017). The implementation of the policy was also aided by the onset of the détente decade between the Western and Socialist blocs, making the imminent threat from the USSR and the need for reliance on US deterrence less salient (Boniface, 2021). With the subsequent withdrawal from NATO's integrated command structure in 1966, the singularity of French strategic autonomy was a reality, creating a political movement in French society that would prove extremely long-lived. (Schmitt, 2017).

The Gaullist approach to French defense thus centers on the notion of the nation achieving strategic autonomy, above all from the United States. It has been expressed in various ways over the years, ranging from a soft skepticism to NATO to an outspoken desire of leaving the alliance permanently. Since the end of the Cold War, sovereigntists have increasingly come to define their opposition to Atlanticism not as a rejection of partnership with the United States per se, but as an objection towards the organizational characteristics of NATO specifically (Schmitt, 2017). Cooperation with the USA should be allowed to continue, but the unequal platform of the North Atlantic Alliance should be reformed or dismantled.

In general terms, the French far right is anti-Atlanticist and over time has best personified the Gaullist tradition on the matter, while the left and far left also tend to put on view a defiant stance. The largest far-right party, and

currently largest single party in the French National Assembly, is *Rassemblement National* (National Rally, RN, formerly known as *Front National*), whose leading figure since the early 2010s has been Marine Le Pen. The party leader has frequently referenced Charles de Gaulle and his sense of patriotism as a source of inspiration for her own politics (Lichfield, 2021). Le Pen has vocally opposed further integration of France with other countries, both within the framework of NATO and the European Union. Ahead of the 2022 presidential election, in which she advanced to the second round and received 41% of votes, she declared that if elected, she would once more withdraw the country from NATO's central command, emulating De Gaulle. She nonetheless expressed support for the Article 5 commitment of the North Atlantic Treaty, vowing to honor it if called upon (The New York Times, 2022; France 24, 2022). Importantly, as opposed to the centrist NATO-skeptics, National Rally rejects the idea of building a European defense system, being long-standing Eurosceptics. RN perceive European integration as another constraint on the strategic autonomy pursued by France. In this respect, Le Pen has taken a dim view of the close Franco-German partnership under Emmanuel Macron's and Angela Merkel's leadership, and suggested to end joint military projects between the two nations. The RN has also advocated for improved relations with Russia, including after the onset of the SMO (France 24, 2022). This may be seen both as an expression of ideological proximity to more conservative Russian politics, and as a means of balancing against the United States.

Similar views on NATO have been voiced by Éric Zemmour, founder of far-right political party *Reconquête* (Reconquest), which places to the right of National Rally on the political spectrum. Zemmour has emerged as a vocal critic of NATO enlargement to Eastern Europe, maintaining that NATO was "responsible" for the eruption of armed conflict in Ukraine in 2014 and 2022.

Like Le Pen, he has suggested a warming up of relations with Russia. The Reconquest Party's defense program largely concords with that of National Rally - it is negatively disposed to consolidation of European defense initiatives, promotes a departure from the integrated central command of NATO, and seeks to refocus expenditure on purely French military structures. Zemmour, however, goes further than Le Pen in that he has proposed a drastic augmentation of defense budgets for the country, stating in 2022 that France's military budget should be increased from a current 41 billion euros to 70 billion euros by the end of the decade. Specifically, the party leader suggested constructing a second aircraft carrier and "densifying" the national production of military equipment, while warning against the purchase of weapons from the United States (Loaëc, 2022).

Hostility to NATO also permeates the French far-left parties, including *La France Insoumise* (France Unbowed, LFI), which in recent years has been at the forefront of a series of broad left-wing electoral alliances in the French Parliament. Unlike the far-right parties of Le Pen and Zemmour, the LFI have distanced themselves from calls of rearmament and strengthening of national defense, urging instead to give a more prominent role to the United Nations Security Council for the resolution of military conflicts. The party leader since 2016, Jean-Luc Mélenchon, has proposed on several occasions that France should leave NATO entirely, viewing the alliance as useless (France Info, 2022). He has also echoed Zemmour's talking points on the role of NATO in fomenting a crisis in Ukraine, and promoted a new vision of strategic "non-alignment" for France (Europe 1, 2022). In 2022, the LFI presented a white paper that proposed to leave NATO, outlining possible countermeasures to sanctions from the United States that could potentially follow (La France Insoumise, 2022). The 2022 party program proposed to immediately withdraw from the central command, and then progressively from the whole alliance.

However, by 2024, the party appeared to have softened its stance on NATO, visibly impacted by the protracted conflict in Ukraine (Bourgery-Gonse, 2024).

Thus, the Gaullist tradition assumes diverse forms in modern France. While some politicians call for a partial or complete withdrawal from the transatlantic alliance in favor of a military strategy entirely centered on national defense, there is also an influential interpretation of Gaullism that promotes a reorientation of security planning away from the United States, towards a collective European approach. The latter variant, which is frowned upon by the French far right, is now fully embraced by the centrist, previously mainstream political parties, even as they declare their support for continued presence in NATO. Most notably, it is the line which has been supported by President Emmanuel Macron since entering office in 2017.

Emmanuel Macron as a singular factor in the equation

Macron is a self-declared Gaullist in a broad sense, and perceives his politics at both the domestic and international levels to be consistent with the ideals embodied by Charles de Gaulle (Lichfield, 2021). In the dichotomy of Atlanticism and Sovereigntism, Macron has emerged as a somewhat ambiguous case, at different times displaying different characteristics of both political traditions. The leader, though on occasion having bitterly criticized the alliance, has never proposed to withdraw from it, and has been clear about the responsibilities conferred on his country by Article 5. This would place him firmly within the Atlanticist camp. Nonetheless, Macron has not ceased to advocate for reduced dependence on the United States, both for France and for the European continent as a whole.

The so-called Sorbonne speech delivered by Emmanuel Macron at a university in Paris in September 2017 was indicative of the foreign policy trajectory he intended to develop. Labeled as a “new initiative for Europe”, the allocution placed French security interests in a context of wider European security interests. Macron declared that his objective is to ensure “Europe’s autonomous operating capabilities, in complement to NATO”, and to achieve that aim proposed a number of initiatives, such as the activation of a Permanent Structured Cooperation (PESCO) in the EU, the creation of a European Defence Fund, the establishment of a European Intelligence Academy, and organize a European joint intervention force. Above all, what the EU and France needed was a common strategic culture that would facilitate coordination in defense matters (Élysée, 2017). With the exception of PESCO, which was developed the same year and counts dozens of joint military projects among EU countries, and in which France figures prominently (European Defence Agency, 2025), none of the envisioned blueprints for a united European defense system have been realized. The vision of a more autonomous Europe capable of meeting its own security needs would nevertheless prove a persistent topic throughout Macron’s presidency.

This singular vision is not novel per se, and is present in the rhetoric of other centrist parties and politicians, but has rarely been argued for more forcefully than by Macron. It can be seen as part of a longer tradition that inscribes the defense policy of France within a European collective policy, effectively fusing the French national interest with a purported ‘European national interest’. There is a Gaullist aspect to this conceptualization, as Charles De Gaulle was the originator of the notion of ‘Europe Puissance’ in the 1960s, the idea of a united Europe that could exist independently between the two superpowers of the USA and USSR. De Gaulle allegedly perceived

the European Economic Community, then composed of the Inner Six, as sufficient to propel France back to the preeminent status that it had lost after the defeat of Napoleon I in 1815. The other European states were thus perceived as a useful instrument, which France could wield at its behest to achieve its own national objectives (Lefebvre, 2021; Foreign Policy Association, 2025). The strategic considerations of De Gaulle are still topical. They are grounded in the realization that France on its own does not possess the political, economic and military wherewithal to exercise a dominant role in the international system. As part of a larger Europe where France would be 'first among equals', however, the country would again be able to assert itself on par with the United States and other great powers. It is this idea of 'Europe Puissance' that Emmanuel Macron could be said to attempt to resurrect.

Some policy decisions made over the course of Macron's time in office can be interpreted as a continuation of this particular Gaullist line. For instance, Macron's attempts to lead independent negotiations with Russia prior to and after the SMO is reminiscent of De Gaulle's call for a Europe "from the Atlantic to the Urals" (Lieven, 2024). De Gaulle was a conservative, and thus had little consideration for Marxist ideology. (Boniface, 2021). Similarly, Macron is positioned far to the left on the political spectrum of Russian President Vladimir Putin. The reaching out should therefore be seen more as a stratagem to distance the USA and increase France's standing internationally. The approach adopted by Macron in the later stages of the Ukrainian conflict, which has featured more outspoken support for the Ukrainian side, could also be understood as a reaction to US developments. After the landslide victories in the primaries of early 2024, it became clear that Donald Trump would most likely be the Republican candidate at the 2024 US presidential election, creating the realistic prospect of a lessened American support for the Ukrainian war effort by the end of that

year. However, it could also be argued that Macron's gradually stronger support for Ukraine is motivated by domestic considerations and the rise in popularity of the far right. Taking a firmer stance for Ukraine and against Russia could be an attempt to damage the reputation of RN, since Le Pen was formerly perceived as close to Putin (Lieven, 2024).

In line with the intensification of the Special Military Operation and wavering of the White House in its funding of Ukraine in late 2023 and early 2024, Emmanuel Macron doubled down in his discourse on an autonomous Europe in defense matters. His more proactive stance most notably found expression in open speculation about the transfer of European combat troops to Ukraine (Breeden & Méheut, 2024), but was also apparent in his attempts to rally other European leaders for the cause. In a state visit to Sweden in January 2024, Macron openly proclaimed that "part of out vital interests have a European dimension", and that France in that regard has a "special responsibility" (Fayet, 2024). Returning to the Sorbonne University in April 2024, Macron reiterated many of the same points stated in the speech delivered seven years earlier, highlighting the consistency of his strategic vision. In terms of security issues, he argued, Europe and France "cannot be addressed separately" (Élysée, 2024).

3.2 Summary of the findings

French and American strategic culture alike underwent noteworthy changes in the studied period. The United States' security strategy was highly volatile, partly so due to the change of administrations in 2021, while French defense policy was overall characterized by more consistency, albeit not without unexpected twists and turns. US foreign policy responded largely to its own internal motivations grounded in its national identity and the high

level of political polarization occurring in recent years, as well as to the course of action of a select number of states, foremost of which were Russia, China and Israel. France, though an important ally, does not appear to have had a decisive impact on the formulation of American policy, even in spheres where the two countries worked closely together to achieve shared goals. The same, however, can not be said the other way around - it is clear that French defense policy in a large number of cases has oriented itself on the actions of the United States, or to some degree or other has been formulated as a reaction to political developments on the other side of the Atlantic.

US-French military cooperation throughout the period has spanned a number of fields and theaters of operation. French forces have been actively engaged alongside their American colleagues in counterterrorist campaigns in Afghanistan, Syria, the Sahel and the Red Sea, in military exercises within the North Atlantic framework as well as outside of it, such as in the Indo-Pacific, and have provided large-scale financial, logistical and material support to third-party countries outside NATO with which both countries have close political ties, most notably Ukraine and Israel.

In most operations, French forces played a supportive, though not always subordinate, role to a larger mission or strategic aim pursued by the USA. Such was the case in Afghanistan, where French presence was made possible by the US twenty-year occupation of the country, in Syria, where France to a great extent relied on US efforts to successfully conduct its policy of rollback towards the Islamic State, and in the waters off the Yemeni coast, where the United States has taken the main initiative in ensuring the free passage of commercial vessels. France also assisted Israel to a lesser extent than the United States, delivering significantly fewer weapons and equipment, as well as assuming a less prominent role in interactions with Iran. A notable exception where the roles to some extent appear to be inverted is the mission

in the Sahel, where French investment and troops clearly outnumbered those of the American partner. It should, however, be taken into account that West Africa was of low strategic priority for both the Trump and Biden administrations, and that there was never any pronounced conflict of interest between France and the United States in the Sahel, with the US objectives for the region largely overlapping with those of France. Thus, in most cases France acted as a junior partner to the USA in the two countries' joint military engagements, and French behavior internationally can often be described as bandwagoning, an implicit acknowledgement of French dependence on the United States. A clear example of that was Emmanuel Macron's separate line of negotiations with Russian President Vladimir Putin in the weeks preceding the start of the SMO - the French effort was partly aimed at setting up a summit between Joe Biden and Putin, underscoring France's insufficiency in dealing with Russia on equal terms. However, the perception of France as a mere bandwagon or subordinate partner to the USA needs to be nuanced.

The United States can be said to have influenced France in multiple ways, though the extent of the influence has its limitations. First, the United States has affected France through the alteration of its strategic visions and priorities. There is clearly a paradigmatic change unfolding in the American worldview, with the long-expected 'pivot to Asia' finally gathering momentum under the Trump and Biden administrations. This has relegated Europe, and by implication France as well, to a second place in the US ranking of priorities. At the same time, France has since the late 2000s become reintegrated into the transatlantic framework to a much greater degree than before, with Atlanticist currents in French political life gaining traction in the years that preceded the Asian pivot of 2017 onwards. There has manifestly been an American attempt to entangle its European allies in its growing great power competition with China, notably by using the North Atlantic platform

to rally support, as seen by the increasingly preponderant attention devoted to the PRC in NATO discourse, a tendency that began under Donald Trump's first presidency. While this strategy has given mixed results so far, France has been more receptive to it than most European partners, at least in part because the country possesses significant overseas territories in the Indian and Pacific Oceans. In France, the 'pivot to Asia' thus manifested itself with a similar trend, as can be observed by the prompt adoption of the new US geopolitical concept of the 'Indo-Pacific', and the release of its own official Indo-Pacific strategy. The French worldview is consequently to some extent informed by the American, most plainly evidenced by the identification of China as a challenger to the status quo and established order in the region. Still, there was no full alignment with US interests in the area due to French reservations, which will be discussed below.

Second, the USA influenced France indirectly through its approach to the North Atlantic Treaty Organization. Considering the weight of NATO in framing the defense relations between the United States and its European allies, including France, any examination of US-French relations in the military domain will necessarily put emphasis on the transatlantic partnership as an instrument that conveyed policy change. The USA underwent a major overhaul of its policy towards the alliance, with ripple effects on the other members. Under the leadership of Donald Trump, the main axis of the new American NATO policy was the notion of collective burden sharing, with virulent criticism of perceived European free riders. However, budget questions per se were probably the aspect of US policy that had the least effect on French defense policy throughout the period. At the beginning of the study's timeframe, France was already quite close to the target rate of 2% of GDP, and subsequent French increases of the defense budget over the period are in the 0.1-0.2% range (NATO Public Diplomacy Division, 2024a). These

fluctuations are rather negligible compared to those of other NATO member states, where the impact of US pressure was ostensibly more strongly felt. Several considerations help explain the limited French response in terms of defense expenditure. First, France is by itself already continental Europe's strongest state in terms of military power (excluding Russia and Ukraine). The asymmetry in spending between the United States and the other NATO members was essentially due to the large deficit in other states' spending, and the Trumpian criticism could therefore be said to have been mostly addressed to other European countries. Second, France's long-standing insistence on 'autonomy', which has among other things translated into an independent nuclear weapons program, by extension also comprises autonomy vis-a-vis NATO, despite an intensification of French participation in the organization in the 2010s. This autonomy gives France some leverage to resist potential pressures emanating from the White House. Lastly, in relation to the other European countries in the transatlantic alliance, France is to a much greater degree self-reliant in the domain of security, in particular compared to smaller European states (e.g. Belgium), but also larger ones (e.g. Germany), that rely much more on the United States for their national security. With a growing perception in the alliance of Russia as the main strategic competitor and external threat, France's geographic location in Western Europe also grants it some advantages that deflate the Russian threat perception promoted by Donald Trump.

A more compelling thought is the degree to which Emmanuel Macron could actually be said to concur with the general philosophy of the new approach to NATO ushered in by the Trump administration. As opposed to other members, who responded with perplexity or objections, it appears that France rather welcomed the American demands for increased military expenditure. A Europe that collectively spends more on defense could

facilitate the emergence of a clearer 'European pillar' in NATO by rebalancing the disequilibrium in military might between the two sides of the Atlantic, and could in the longer-term perspective also lay the ground for a possible European defense system that operates independently of the United States, a long-standing ambition of Emmanuel Macron. At any rate, it would in theory allow Macron's France to leverage to a greater extent the collective military power of a united Europe. The relative antipathy exhibited by Macron towards Trump in the later stages of the latter's mandate must thus be caused by other factors. To all appearances Macron by and large took issue with Donald Trump's general animosity towards multilateral institutions and practices, considering that multilateralism is a cornerstone of France's foreign policy and wider worldview. This also extends to the French foreign policy, notwithstanding whether it is interpreted through the prism of Atlanticism (that is, personified as NATO) or sovereigntism (in which the 'Europeanist' interpretation of autonomy is gaining clout). Trump's flouting of intergovernmental institutions and the disdainful rhetoric employed when commenting on allies was clearly not to France's liking. The spontaneity and ad hoc approaches sometimes used by Trump also caused visible irritation with Macron, and fostered the feeling that France was not valued enough as a strategic partner. A clear example of that was the US decision to pull out its troops from Northeast Syria in 2019, effectively undermining efforts by an international coalition to contain ISIS, and provoking caustic comments by Macron on the state of their alliance.

Third, the drastic variations in US foreign policy, especially what concerns NATO, translated into specific political dynamics in France. The fluctuations in US policy that resulted from the change in both president and governing party in 2017 and 2021 were far more profound than what is common in the United States. The contrasts between the Trump and Biden

administrations were epitomized by the sharp transformations of discourse on NATO that occurred over the period. These developments in turn activated different movements in French political life and led to policy adjustments. Thus, beyond systemic factors, domestic factors in the shape of opposed political currents in French society also impacted on the final policies formulated at the Élysée Palace.

Since the late 2000s, France had modified its stance in relation to NATO and had embraced close cooperation with partners in the alliance. The main centrist parties, PS and LR, which represent the political forces in France that are the most favorably disposed to the transatlantic alliance, arguably became more Atlanticist than they had been previously, beginning to underscore the desirability of greater French participation in the organization, and discarding past talking points about the benefits of remaining outside the integrated central command. These parties have thus placed themselves in opposition to the antagonistic approach of Trump, and are politically much closer to the line adopted by Joe Biden. Curiously, these traditional, more Atlanticist parties have lost ground in recent national elections, with the Socialist Party collapsing entirely. There has been considerable polarization of the political landscape, with voters being drawn to far-left and far-right parties, which hold anti-Atlanticist positions. Consequently, Emmanuel Macron's centrist Renaissance Party has emerged as the foremost representative of the pro-NATO section in French politics, despite there being significant Gaullist undercurrents in that party as well.

There thus appears to have been a general weakening of Atlanticist ideology in French politics to the benefit of the Gaullist tradition. It is notable that politicians with hardcore, conservative interpretations of Gaullism, such as Marine Le Pen and Éric Zemmour, who reject both transatlantic and European defense cooperation in favor of a purely nationalist defense strategy,

have strengthened their standing, almost to the point of becoming mainstream candidates in elections. However, it is difficult to attribute this rise to a possible influence from Donald Trump with any certainty. The increase in the popularity of the far right is a global trend that is observed across many states, and French voters tend to be far more concerned with domestic issues such as the economy and migration that with foreign policy. It is likewise problematic to advance the hypothesis that Trump's NATO policy energized sovereigntist tendencies among the far right. While this may be so, it should be noted that the members of National Rally, the largest far-right party in France, have been consistently Gaullist and Eurosceptic for decades, making any positive affirmations the product of guesswork.

Whether there is a causal link or not between the election of Donald Trump and the surge in popularity of Le Pen, it is clear that the two are ideologically close, sharing a preference for a more isolationist policy, whether in defense, trade or elsewhere. Again, this implies that Macron stands in opposition to both Trump and the French far right, as a relatively more Atlanticist politician. The most interesting finding is therefore that the approach taken by Emmanuel Macron to French defense policy is nevertheless motivated by strong Gaullist predispositions. What is more, the strength with which these Gaullist inclinations are assumed seems to vary in accordance with the White House's policy towards NATO. When the United States castigated the alliance under Trump, France tended to promote greater European strategic autonomy from the USA. When the United States renewed their commitments to NATO under Biden, France followed suit and appeared to reaffirm the importance of the transatlantic partnership with the USA.

Upon entering office, Emmanuel Macron began to vividly argue in favor of a stronger European defense, one in which France would play a primary role, all while permitting himself bouts of outspoken criticism of the

transatlantic alliance. His criticism was generally formulated more delicately than that of Trump. The climate created by Trump's verbal onslaught on NATO made it possible to voice more unconventional views on the organization than what had been the case previously, when NATO was tacitly accepted as a staple in international life not to be questioned. Emmanuel Macron manifestly seized this occasion, as exemplified by his Sorbonne speech and other public declarations of the same sort. However, Trump's own view of NATO softened somewhat over the course of his first mandate, which over time created some disparity in their outlooks. The lowest point in the French president's attitude to NATO was in late 2019, when he characterized the alliance as suffering from "brain death", which generated a negative reaction from Trump himself. This can be interpreted as a case where Macron miscalculated and overstepped the limits of acceptable criticism of the transatlantic alliance, as seen from the United States. He subsequently moderated his wording, and by the arrival of Joe Biden in the White House in 2021 had adopted a far more reconciliatory style, in which the importance of cooperation with American and other NATO allies was accentuated. Macron would yet again begin to reemphasize the need to develop closer defense ties among European countries throughout 2024, in parallel with Donald Trump clinching a string of victories in the Republican primaries and emerging as the likely candidate for the Republicans at the 2024 US presidential election. The prospect of the isolationist and NATO-sceptic Trump being reelected to the White House, which appeared increasingly probable over the course of 2024, and even more so as Joe Biden's public approval was in conspicuous decline, seems to have fueled Emmanuel Macron's Gaullist instincts. Thus, French commitment to NATO waxed and waned with American declared commitment.

The particular branch of Gaullism Macron adheres to is the softer variant, which reevaluates French strategic autonomy as 'European strategic autonomy', above all from the United States. This interpretation of French autonomy has always been present since the days of De Gaulle, for example enjoying a brief revival under Jacques Chirac in the 1990s, but it is clear that it has become much more influential under the leadership of Emmanuel Macron, despite Macron regularly professing his unswerving commitment to NATO. France can thus be understood to attempt to 'ride two horses at the same time', adapting its policy in accordance with what is most beneficial at any given point in time. It is notable that the French president, even during the rapprochement phase that followed Joe Biden's election, never really ceased to promote a European vision for defense. One of his foremost achievements in this regard was to have Biden consistently refer to the necessity of a European defense system in his public statements, one that would be complementary to the US-led NATO. In terms of institutional developments, France also had some moderate successes during the Trump and Biden administrations, with European defense alternatives materializing in the Permanent Structured Cooperation and the European Intervention Initiative, with the latter being headquartered in Paris. However, these projects are not remotely comparable to NATO in scope.

In other words, the vacillating US policy towards NATO was acutely felt by many European members of the alliance and fostered uncertainty about US reliability as a security guarantor for Europe, a development that France clearly tried to capitalize on by advancing its own security alternatives, in which it would have one of the principal roles, if not the leading role.

Thus, the traditional French pursuit of 'strategic autonomy' is evidently well alive, and has gained prominence in its Europeanist incarnation. The search for strategic autonomy also translated into practice in multiple other

dimensions of French defense policy. The French response to the escalation of fighting in Ukraine in February 2022 is a case in point. Emmanuel Macron chose to maintain diplomatic contact with Russian President Vladimir Putin for many months after the start of the Special Military Operation, whereas Biden opted to cut all direct dialogue with his Russian counterpart. This can be inscribed in a broader French tendency of dampened hostility to Russia compared to the USA. All while standing firmly in the Western camp, France has been wary to not antagonize Russia excessively or to alienate the Russian leadership beyond a point of no return, giving priority to a more balanced diplomatic approach of its own making. This is vaguely reminiscent of the Cold War approach developed by De Gaulle, encapsulated in the slogan 'allied, but non-aligned', and can be interpreted as an attempt at softly balancing the United States. This strategic maneuvering is also discernable in the attitude displayed to Ukraine over the course of the SMO. France was initially among the less supportive members of the Western coalition against Russia, at a time when Joe Biden was adamant in his backing of Ukraine and became its most prominent supporter. Over time, however, as the USA grew more hesitant, with a major aid package stalling for months in the Congress and Trump triumphing in the 2024 electoral race, France adjusted its position, progressively transforming itself into one of the most prominent supporters of the Ukrainian cause. France thus flaunted a policy that was the reverse of the American one.

Another notable instance in which France applied the concept of strategic autonomy was its policy in the Indo-Pacific. Yet again the preferred course was that of 'allied, but non-aligned'. The period witnessed an increase in French interest for the region that was manifestly influenced by the US 'pivot to Asia', and there was a partial overlap of the French and American conceptualization of the growing security challenges. Still, France opted for a

partial, not full alignment with the United States and its surging Quad framework, insisting instead on cultivating its bilateral relations with the different actors in the Indo-Pacific. The country was also careful to distance itself from 'Cold War'-style rhetoric and bipolar competition dynamics in the Indo-Pacific, and promoted an expanded EU presence in the region, in line with the Europeanist version of Gaullism.

Finally, an adherence to the notion of 'strategic autonomy' was applied in the French Middle Eastern policy as well, albeit less emphatically than in the cases of Ukraine and the Indo-Pacific. The French armed forces underscored their autonomy from US command during its patrolling of the Red Sea in Operation Prosperity Guardian in rather unequivocal wording. In the later stages of the management of the Gaza War, the French and US approaches began to diverge, and US influence on the French response to the Israeli-Palestinian conflict became less pronounced. French bandwagoning with US interests toned down to the benefit of its own national interests, such as defending the sovereign rights of Lebanon, a country with which France has close cultural and historical ties, and taking the liberty to criticize Israel more for its military campaign in Gaza. Both actions can be understood as a French attempt at rapprochement with the Arab countries in the region, contrasting with the fiercely pro-Israeli line pursued by the United States.

Conclusion

The defense policies and strategic outlook of the United States have undergone considerable modifications over the last decade or so, as have those of France. The unconventional approach chosen by Donald Trump, which initially appeared as an anomaly in US politics, most notably as concerns the management of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization, could now be reassessed as having ushered in new norms due to their long-lasting impact, even more so as Trump has been reelected to a second term in office. The impact was absorbed by American allies, the oldest of which, France, can be said to have devised parts of its national defense strategy under the influence of the changes that unfolded under Donald Trump and Joe Biden over the period 2017-2025.

By meticulously retracing the main events and developments over the time frame, his study has shown that paradigmatic shifts in US strategic thinking were paralleled in French defense policy, though France's maneuvering on the international arena must also be seen in light of domestic political traditions with deep historical roots. The systemic factors, as described in realist theory, can to some extent account for France's behavior in the studied period. Above all, the power differential between the USA and France is a good indicator. The United States is the undisputed superpower in the international system, while France is a state which operates in the grey zone between great power and middle power status, though it does possess the potential of becoming a superpower as part of a consolidated European Union with a unified, coherent foreign policy. This potential remains largely untapped to this day, by France as by other EU member states, but does inform the French worldview in important ways. Considering the discrepancy in military might and France's status as an ally, it would be expected of France to adhere to the strategy of bandwagoning with the United States.

Indeed, bandwagoning occurred frequently throughout the studied time frame. The backing of Ukraine, the intervention in Syria and the support for Israel are all instances of this. However, there were also many cases where France did not fully align with the US preferred policy, but deviated significantly, a behavior which may be interpreted as attempts to balance the USA, to the extent that the power differential allows it. Domestic factors are key to understand the interplay between France's bandwagoning and balancing strategies.

French strategic culture has historically been split between two opposing visions that emerged in the early Cold War. One, Atlanticism, favors close cooperation with the United States, if not outright subordination, and is chiefly embodied in the North Atlantic Treaty Organization. The other, Gaullism, has given priority to France achieving strategic autonomy from the USA and pursuing an independent foreign and defense policy. The main expression of the Gaullist vein in French politics was the decision to stay outside of NATO's integrated central command between 1966 and 2009. The study has found that the Gaullist dimension has been significantly strengthened over the last decade, represented by a surge in popularity of the French far right, with the governing party Renaissance also having a clear Gaullist component. The Atlanticist movement, represented by centrist parties, has experienced a relative weakening. It is difficult to ascertain any direct US influence on the evolution of the conventional centrist and far-right parties. The study did, however, conclude that American political dynamics shaped the foreign policy adopted by French President Emmanuel Macron.

Among the overarching tendencies in US foreign policy over the entire studied period was the 'pivot to Asia', which highlighted Asia as the foremost region of interest to the USA and framed the People's Republic of China as the United States' chief competitor globally, all to the detriment of Europe,

which has now been demoted to a second position in the US ranking of priorities. This change in course was arguably more rhetorical than practical, as the main concerns during Joe Biden's presidency continued to be Europe and the Middle East, largely due to the two major conflicts in Ukraine and Gaza erupting during his time in office. At any rate there was a reevaluation of the transatlantic relationship by Washington, D.C., with clear demands that the European members of the alliance step up their defense spending as the US implemented its pivot to Asia. This policy, announced by Trump, but continued under Biden, appears to have affected French defense expenditure to a limited degree. It did, however, have significant implications for France's relations with the other European members of NATO.

Emmanuel Macron, while on the surface an Atlanticist, exhibits a worldview that is strongly influenced by a moderate variant of Gaullism that identifies the French national interest with broader European strategic autonomy. It is a pragmatic approach that acknowledges the contemporary limits to French power projection, and seeks to mitigate these shortcomings by pooling its resources with those of other European states. Macron has consistently promoted the creation of a more effective European defense system during his presidency, and conspicuously sought to exploit the increased uncertainty among other allies about US reliability to promote a European vision of defense. This is apparent from the variation in French discourse, which accentuated the need for more close-knit European defense cooperation when the USA expressed weakened commitment to NATO (under Trump), but reaffirmed transatlantic bonds when the USA veered back to a more conventional Atlanticist pattern of conduct (under Biden). Thus, French strategies of bandwagoning and soft balancing alternated with fluctuations in US NATO policy.

The French also pursued strategic autonomy from the United States in a number of cases outside the scope of the North Atlantic framework. This was most notably palpable in the Indo-Pacific policy adopted by France, which values bilateral relations over coalition-building and consciously avoids the bipolarization of the region espoused by the United States. France consequently resisted full alignment with the USA, though it still acts as an ally in the Indo-Pacific. The variation in the French approach to Russia and Ukraine can arguably also be interpreted as a game plan to create further distance between themselves and the White House. Other instances include the French policy towards the Arab-Israeli conflict after the onset of the Gaza War, in particular its handling of aspects related to the Red Sea and Lebanon fronts.

Beyond French posturing vis-a-vis the USA, relations between the two countries were generally cordial, except for a few moments of heightened tensions that resulted from adverse French reaction to defense policies chosen by the United States. These include the decision to withdraw American combat troops from Northeast Syria in late 2019 and, most of all, the announcement of AUKUS in late 2021, which led to a souring of bilateral relations. It is still too early to conclude whether the latter incident has permanently damaged US-French defense cooperation, though the diplomatic crisis between the countries was only a temporary one.

The return of Donald Trump to the White House in January 2021, the endpoint of the time frame of this study, has given renewed relevance to the topic of transatlantic security cooperation. Against the background of the conflict in Ukraine, the resumed criticism of European allies by the second Trump administration has cast serious doubt on the viability of NATO as a security framework for Europe. It is still an open question whether the European Union, if called upon, will be able to successfully transition to a

purely European defense system, and whether France will have the capacity to steer a project of such amplitude. The French government has recently intensified its efforts to bring about a European collective defense, but faces significant hurdles, including reticence by Eastern European states such as Poland and the Baltics to renounce the USA as their main security guarantor, difficulties in coordinating efforts and smoothing out differences among the 27 member states, as well as an economically weakened German partner, which would be indispensable in boosting a European defense industry that manufactures its own equipment and weapons.

There are multiple possibilities for further research on this topic. In particular, it would be valuable to examine in more detail the interactions between the French far right and French defense policy, considering the relatively high probability that National Rally may win a presidential election in 2027 or have a Prime Minister appointed in the near future. Increased political clout of the far right may not only lead to deviations and distortions in bilateral relations with the United States, but also compromise the European integration process within the domain of the Common Security and Defense Policy. The role of the European Union as an independent actor with its own agency could also be researched, to elucidate the degree to which it affects US-French bilateral relations, and better understand the developments over the last decade in the sphere of collective European defense. It would then be beneficial to study the issue from another methodological perspective, for instance combining discourse analysis with a social constructivist framework.

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Appendix

TABLE 1

Comparison of keyword frequencies in the 2015, 2017 and 2022 National Security Strategies

Key word	Obama (2015)	Trump (2017)	Biden (2022)
Al-Qaeda/Al-Qa'ida	9	9	3
Asia, Asian(s)	29	17	9
China, PRC, Chinese	15	38	57
Competition, competitor(s), competitive, competitiveness, compete	10	57	102
Democracy(ies), democratic	45	28	99
Europe, European(s)	21	29	35
France, French	1	0	1

Iran, Iranian(s)	11	17	7
ISIS, Islamic State	11	12	2
North Korea, North Korean(s), DPRK	3	16	3
NATO, North Atlantic Treaty Organization, transatlantic (security, partnership etc.)	9	6	19
Russia, Russian(s), Russian Federation	15	25	71
Syria (civil war)	1	6	3
Terrorism, terrorist(s)	37	70	37
Threat(s), threaten	53	110	69
Ukraine, Ukrainian(s)	7	1	33
War(s), warfare, warfighting	15	39	31